The Perfect Score Became the Perfect Place to Die

THE ASTEROID HEIST

A SCIENCE FICTION CRIME NOVEL

REX HURST

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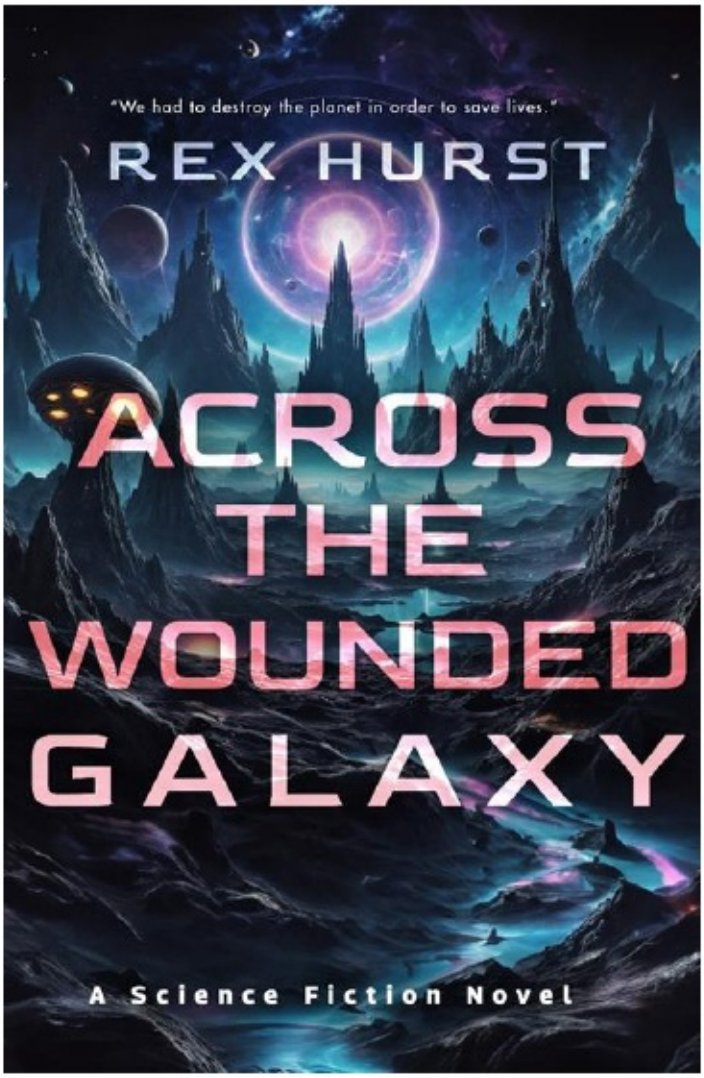

Jake Pool:
The Asteroid Heist

Rex Hurst

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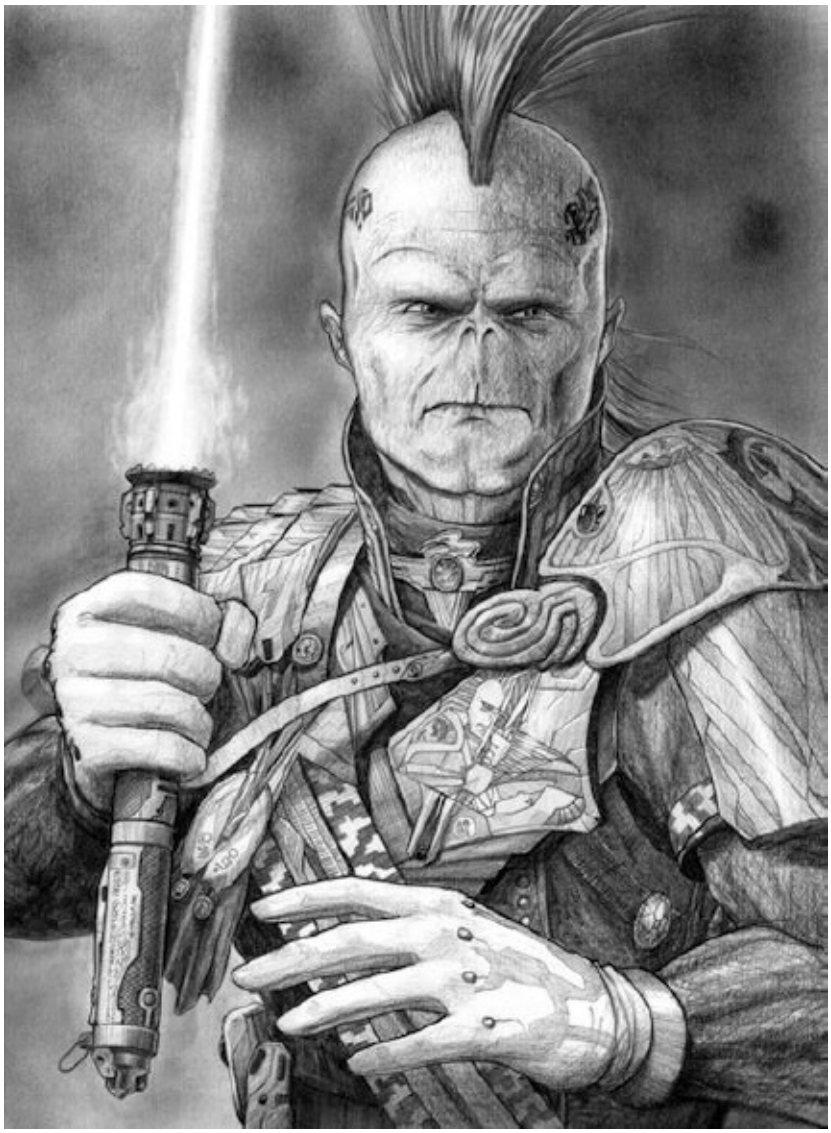

Eridani

Goola-Goola

Mazian

Ram Python

Definition of Terms

Galactic Alliance: The most prominent ruling body in the Milky Way Galaxy, first formed as a mutual defense pact against an invading enemy bent on the enslavement of its member races

Galactic Basic: An artificial language used by the Alliance bureaucracy in all official correspondence, transactions, treaties, and legislation. It was designed to purge any individual idiosyncrasies and idioms native to one species. Thus, making it a flat sterile thing, perfect for legal work.

Galactic Alliance Calendar: Due to the vast differences between the planetary rotations of Alliance worlds and the length of their solar orbits, the Alliance lower council created a standard calendar set for bureaucratic and military business. The breakdown of time units is:

Standard Minute: 100 seconds
Standard Hour: 100 minutes
Standard Day: A 30-hour period of time.
Standard Week: 7 standard days.
Standard Month: 5 standard weeks.
Standard Year: 350 standard days, or ten standard months.

Part I – The Bid

Jake Pool darted down the marble avenues of the artificial city inside of Mylligan's Rock. The meeting was supposed to be in an hour, but he was delayed. Someone was behind him, following his footsteps.

The shadow had been there for the last half hour, writing down every place he sat, watching every little purchase at the stalls, noting every street he navigated.

The guy was good enough to have remained undetected for a while, but he was just one sentient doing a six-man tailing job. Bound to be caught. Jake led him down some unfriendly backstreets, searching for the right spot to strike.

Jake was tall and brutish with creamy skin and flaxen hair. Most dirtbags took one look at him and ran into the opposite direction. So, whoever was following was either mighty brave or mighty stupid. Jake was gambling on the latter.

Mylligan's Rock was well named, having been formed from the hollowed-out moon of a planet which had exploded an epoch ago. The Rock, after settling into its current orbit, was one of those places which seemed to have been around forever. Records of it dated back some fifteen thousand years.

It had gone from being an Alliance staging base, to an Orion mining town, to a military zero-gee training center, to a prison, to a failed dry dock facility, to a pirate base, and now to its current venture - the ultimate expression of the free market at play.

Several decades ago, it had been bought outright by the Orion billionaire, Asen Mylligan, who converted it into a free port. Nominally the facilities were just for use by Alliance races, but in practice Mylligan allowed entrance to anyone who wanted to buy or sell. Soon, it had become the "go to" place for any sort of illicit activity in the surrounding sectors.

Three firms of lawyers had been made rich defending Mylligan's private property rights in the Galactic courts, and the Orion had become even richer by taking a piece of every transaction occurring on his property. And with an average of a million and a half sentients on Mylligan's Rock at any one time, the credits racked up at an incredible rate.

Jake dipped around the corner of a back alley and waited. His shadow followed twenty seconds later. He grabbed the sentient and slammed him against the wall, hard.

It was an Orion. Similar in build to a human, but smaller, with pointed ears and seven fingers on each hand. As a professional thief, or "jobsman" as the interstellar parlance went, Jake had had plenty of dealings with the race, but rarely worked with

the same one twice. When problems arose in a crew, the cause was usually an Orion.

Jake's strength surprised his shadow. He lifted the Orion off his feet with one hand and slowly began choking the life of out him. The victim's eyes bulged. His face turned purple.

"Ready to talk yet?" Jake snarled.

The pinned Orion nodded, his eyes showing a practiced look of confusion as if it were all a big misunderstanding. But once released, the Orion flipped out a blade and took a swipe at Jake's nose. With ease, the jobsman knocked the weapon away and slammed the Orion's head into the wall, face first.

SNAP.

Damn it. Broken neck. When you're constantly jumping from one gravity to another, miscalculations about foot pounds of pressure were bound to happen. Jake had overcompensated, leaving him with a corpse rather than an intimidated informer.

Ah, well.

He went through the Orion's pockets. Not much was there: a credit stick with twenty-five credits on it, an inject-tube filled with some sort of narcotic solution —the Orions had so many it was difficult to keep track—, an electronic lockpick set – old style, half the frequencies were out of date— and a power shunt, which was used to short out electronic systems.

The rubbish told a pretty tale. Low-life junkie. Opportunistic thief. He snatched a datapad off the thief's wrist.

A common gadget throughout Alliance space, the wrist datapad acted as a universal communication and information storage device. By law, they had to be built to a specific industry standard so they could be used in any system in the Alliance. But that meant the weaknesses were standardized as well.

Jake used the demagnitzer on the thief's lockpick set to remove the datapad's face. He then produced a small cracking kit, connected it to his own personal datapad, and wired his system into the dead Orion's unit.

DNA, retinal, and voice recognition security systems were all good protection measures, and even better when connected to temperature regulators, but they still depended on the information presented matching what was stored in the machine. If you bypassed the info storage, as Jake was doing, a sentient could reset the security system to default and then program in anything they wanted.

One, two, three. Scan. Input. Voila! The whole of the alien's life opened like magic.

And what a loser life it was! Browser history showed mostly pornography and violent action films from the local vid flows, as well as plenty of traffic on the

sports gambling sites. The Orion's email had not been properly encrypted, but there wasn't anything in it except spam and threats from debt collectors.

One little chat box yielded gold, however.

It was obviously meant to be deleted, originating from a burner line – a fake datapad ID meant to be used once and thrown away. The chat box held a picture of Jake from eight years ago and gave details on when he was arriving and where he was headed.

Beneath the photo were instructions ordering the dead Orion to follow Jake and let the person on the other end know if he deviated from a direct course. No reply had been sent.

Jake knew he should pack it in right then. The smart odds, the correct calculations, said the job was spoiled. If things started off wrong, rarely did they become right. And a dead body before the pitch was about as askew as it could get.

Yet, the jobsman didn't leave. He was desperate for money. He did not simply want this job. He *needed* it.

It was three standard months since he last worked, and despite that job yielding a sizeable pull that should have lasted the most lavish spendthrift at least six months, Jake had all sorts of hidden expenses which had gobbled up his cut.

He knew it was a gamble to take another job so soon. Too much crime tended to draw authoritarian notice. Patterns emerged and, all of a sudden, a file you weren't aware of was being investigated by agents of Galactic Control. But needs must as the Devil dances. He was here now. Might as well listen to the pitch.

Jake located the meet. It was a stone house, carved from marble with metal doors. The marble of Mylligan's Rock had a natural impurity that interfered with all sound-tapping methods. Outside, it looked positively primitive. Yet Jake knew that inside, wormed through the walls like habit trails, lay all the modern electric accouterments of civilization. These structures dotted the city and were rentable by the hour.

He hid by the side of the house and sent a message along the burner line.

Get out of there! He's around back with a pulse cannon about to blast his way in. Hurry!

The door flew open and Gurt Lynt stumbled out of the house. Lynt was another Orion and Jake's contact on Mylligan's Rock. A las pistol fumbled in his hands.

Lynt was an old jobsman, not really fit for duty anymore, so he earned his ill-gotten bread as a middle man. The friend of a friend. The guy who knows people who knows people. And he certainly knew enough not to pull a stupid stunt like having Jake followed.

The jobsman intercepted Lynt and kicked the gun from his trembling hands, then he knocked the Orion's brains around his skull.

"Stop," Lynt cried. "I'm sorry. It wasn't my idea."

Jake hefted his fist. "That so?"

"It was Cullidan. He insisted. And I figured what's the harm? Put the guy at ease."

"Put *him* at ease?"

Jake filtered through his memory. The name Cullidan didn't pop up. By itself that didn't mean much. Across the galaxy there were probably millions of competent jobsmen Jake hadn't heard of. Yet, a new name should always be met with caution.

"Lead the way," he ordered and pushed Lynt into the building.

It was a four-room structure. Two exits. No windows. The inside was carpeted on all surfaces to keep the natural clamminess of the stone at bay. Seated on a plush divan was a member of the last race Jake would have ever expected to be involved on a job. An Eridani.

Eridani culture was a rigid caste society with the warriors on top, supported by the noble houses. Whenever the Eridani were about aliens, they were supposed to be representing their race to the "inferior peoples" of the galaxy. Any slight to one them was a slap at the entire culture. Every game became a test to display their superiority. Even a casual round of checkers could become a tension-filled violent exercise when the Eridani were involved.

The few Eridani Jake had met were career military. Upright figures in peak physical condition. Not a hair out of place. Not a button unpolished. In the ten years Jake had been pulling jobs, he had never met a crooked Eridani. It just didn't happen.

Until now.

There was something sick and seedy about this specimen. His race's coloration tended towards a deep yellow. Yet Cullidan's was darker, like old urine, and a sour smell lingered on his collar.

Cullidan wore no military or house insignia, which was unusual for an Eridani. The clothes he had on were slovenly, uncleaned. A distinctive pot belly flopped about his midsection and his arms were ropey, the flesh sagged off them. If he had ever exercised, the effects were long gone. He sure as hell wasn't casting his race in a positive light.

"Come on in," Cullidan said. "Pull up some air. We're just waiting on the other guy."

"The one following me?"

"Not that idiot. He's just a stooge."

"Good, because he's dead."

Cullidan's eyes jumped. He tried to cover it by adjusting the breather mask on

his face, but the sentient was clearly rattled. The Eridani were natural methane breathers. Oxygen was poison to them. There were rooms for rent in the city with a methane atmosphere, but he had chosen otherwise.

Lynt eagerly ran over and helped him with the mask. That was another odd thing. Traditionally, Orions and Eridani hated each other. The reason stretched far back in time to some ancient battle, but these two seemed to have gotten over their racial prejudices.

Jake settled in a chair and relaxed, as much someone like him could relax. He took in the pair who were laughing together over some private joke. Even the Eridani's name was twisted, he realized. It should have been Culli-iden, but somewhere along the line it had been corrupted.

"So, what're your back pulls?" he asked Cullidan. "Who do you know? Besides Lynt there and I don't consider him much of a character reference after today." The elder Orion pouted, but said nothing.

"Let's just say, I'm dangling a hoop." A translated Eridani phrase meaning he was a newbie. "One plan. One big idea. Then I will happily saunter away on the cosmic trails."

An amateur. Probably with a grudge to settle. Perfect. A perfect storm of shit that is.

Jake rose.

"What are you standing tall for?" Cullidan asked.

The entrance buzzer rattled a dying tune. The house's electrics obviously needed some work. Lynt went to the door and let in Aleister Song, a human. That was good. Jake had worked plenty of jobs with Song. Even if he could sometimes be a bit silly, Jake trusted the man's ability absolutely. Had anyone else been at the door, Jake would have walked. Now, he had someone to confer with.

"Not to alarm you all," Song said, "but I was followed on the way here. Don't worry. I killed the guy."

This sparked a hubbub of explanations, recriminations, arguments, and bad feelings all around. Song thought pretty much as Jake did and seemed determined to walk out, until Lynt pleaded with them.

"You're here. Just listen to what he's got to say. It's different, I tell you. Something never done."

"That doesn't mean it's any good," countered Jake. "Usually there's a reason something hasn't been done."

Cullidan tried to put on a friendly smile, but he was obviously furious. He obviously hated being disagreed with.

"I'm told that you're one of the best. That's what I need here. Consider what we talk about a rough draft, then we can edit the plan with your knowledgeable

input."

"It's a three-man job then?" asked Song.

"We're gonna include Lynt along with the rest of us. But consider yourself captains. I figure the whole job is gonna need about twenty in total."

Jake and Song exchanged alarmed looks. That was as big of a red flag as they could imagine. Was it now strike three, or ball four? Either way, it made Jake balk. He began listing Cullidan's mistakes, raising a finger sharply after each point.

"One, you've proved you don't trust us by putting tails on us. Know the kind of people who do that? Untrustworthy ones. Guys who think everyone's trying to rip them off, because that's exactly what they plan to do to everyone else.

"Two, you're an amateur with, I'm guessing here, a personal motive for hitting your target. That means there's an additional purpose beyond profit. A further link between you and the crime. Which is one extra potential clue you're giving up to the whoever looks into it.

"Three, too many involved. It's difficult getting a good crew at the best times. With twenty, the slots will have to be filled by second cousins, green newbies, or idiot wanna-bes. You get more than five on a plan, one of them will screw it up somehow. Maybe they'll tell the little lady and she runs at the mouth. Or one of them brags about his big job to impress a stripper and she tells the hod –"

"The what?" Cullidan asked.

"Hod. Police and whatnot," answered Lynt.

"Or one gets picked up for something stupid and rats on us. So, we go under because some jerk can't stop committing petty crimes," finished Jake.

Cullidan rubbed his chin. Anger, arrogance, consideration, and confusion took turns dancing across his face. He obviously wasn't used to being corrected, certainly not as much as Jake had just done, but he was smart enough to realize the jobsman knew his profession.

"Let's talk about the target and see what you think."

They adjourned into the next room. Jake saw the place was double laden with security devices. All sorts of gadgets had been wired in to prevent eavesdropping through electronic or psychic means, that was in addition to the house's natural immunities. No wonder the electrics were having a hard time. It was total overkill. The only way someone could listen in here would be to literally put their ear to the keyhole.

Holograms flew from Cullidan's datapad, filling the air in the middle of the room, displaying plans and schematics of an asteroid base. It was all very detailed, hot-off-the-presses information. Jake recognized the basic configuration as an Asteroid Mining Corporation outfit.

"This is Maze Base One," Cullidan began, "located in the Maze of Orion belt.

Twenty thousand miners are housed here. The biggest camp in AMC's territories. Three stone towns make up the central area, each on a different asteroid. One is for personal quarters and recreation. One is for mineral storage, vehicle repair, and parking. The third handles administrative duties, system housing, guidance, and security details."

Cullidan went on and on about the base and its parent company. The name pretty much said it all. The corporation, through bribes and efficiency, had cornered the market on asteroid mining, forcing their rivals to strip-mine planets for valuables. While on the surface a planet might seem like a richer field to plunder, a lot of problems popped up on larger spheres that just didn't happen with asteroids.

For one, the constant entering and leaving an atmosphere put considerable wear and tear on vehicles and equipment, adding to costs. Even orbital shots, where the material was thrown into low orbit and scooped up by shuttles, weren't as cost effective as never having to leave zero-gee.

Additionally, whenever a corporation started tearing up a planet that supported life, or could possibly support life in a million years, all sorts of hippie-dippie groups came pouring out of the patchouli-soaked woodwork to protest. Often, they snuck in little clumps of morons to sabotage operations and cause general mayhem. No one worried about asteroids.

Cullidan went on about the internalization of materials and company script, expenses, recreation, and communication between the base and its parent substations, plus those com channels required by Galactic Naval safety guidelines and other bureaucratic legal decrees. Tons of paperwork, media, and informational data was beamed back and forth between the base and government agencies.

Jake kept waiting for the Eridani to get to the point. He figured the score was a load of valuable ore, or some magical alien artifact, or an uncovered supercomputer from a forgotten war, but Cullidan just blathered on about communication methods. Then it dawned on the jobsman what the object of the mission was.

"You're out of your skull," he declared.

"Am I?"

Song looked around. "What am I missing?"

"He's suggesting that we rip off the whole of the digital payroll for Maze Base One. Every six standard months they rotate a quarter of their miners out for mandatory gravity rehab and transmit their money with them."

Of course, Jake knew it wasn't just the payroll being transmitted. Banking could be a long and difficult process in the void of space. To save on the astronomical costs of using the Stargate coms systems, many credit transactions from the sale of ore were transferred from station to station and stored until a scheduled Stargate transmission was ready. They were possibly talking millions here.

Song whistled, a human trait Jake found irritating for reasons he couldn't identify.

"What an idea," he said. "Couldn't really work though."

"Really?" the Eridani laughed.

Then he filled them in on the rest of the plan.

***

Afterwards, Jake sat isolated in a corner of the marble house, going over the details, categorizing them into mental folders then rearranging them, looking for flaws and faults. All the refreshments he had accepted lay uneaten, undrunk, and unsmoked on a low table before him.

Right then, the biggest flaw he found was still in the man rather than the play. Apart from his slovenly attire, two other things really stuck out about Cullidan.

Eridani were unforgiving about failure. Their race's Buddon code required them to commit acts of self-mutilation over any screw up. Penance scars, they called them. Cullidan had none. Not a nick. Not a scratch. No one goes through life without screwing up once. Not unless they blame everyone else for their mistakes.

Secondly, an Eridani's hair, its color and style, represented a person's position in society, or his mindset or mission. In the repressed caste world, hair was symbolic of worth and purpose.

Cullidan was bald. His race didn't naturally go bald, that much Jake knew, so he must've had it shaved off. Pretty much a massive 'screw you' to the whole of his society.

When Jake later mentioned these points to Song, the human had just shrugged.

"So? We're thieves. Jobsmen. None of us is beholden to any set of laws or customs."

"But we don't look like criminals," Jake put in. "You wouldn't pull a job with a sentient who had 'thief for life' tattooed on his head. That's pretty much what we got in there for an Eridani."

***

Jake and Song left Cullidan to his empty rental and dancing holograms, retreating to a nearby greasy spoon to deliberate. Lynt slunk around them like a puppy dog looking for a pat. He received none.

After the waitress served up their bladder burgers – *made from the internal organs of mutated zebras* – and warm Horrokroshcu milk – *all the rage in this sector* – the trio got down to their deliberations.

Lynt was all about the money.

"It's a stellar score. One of the biggest ever. But, as you saw, his plan is screwy, with his wanting to get a battalion of jobsmen for this. Typical Eridani. Always thinking in military terms. That's why I insisted on you two. You need to iron everything out and make it feasible."

Song was in awe of the idea.

"Money's good, but think of the audacity, the daring it would take. That'd be worth doing on its own. It's never been done. It'd be like pulling the first moving train robbery."

The grandeur of Achilles shone in his eyes. His head wasn't on the job, but the story afterwards. The books, the vids, the endless chatter over the flows about the caper. Glory, glory everlasting. Jake slapped the human's mind planet-side.

"You can knock that crap out of your head. The only way this gets big is if they know who done it, otherwise you only have half a story. I'm not getting identified so you can become a paragraph in the galactic crime encyclopedia next to eternal shit-heels like Jackisarious Phentari."

Jake, for all his misgivings, thought mostly about how much he could use that money, about how many problems could be alleviated with that much loot in his grasp at one time.

And even though the red flags kept waving, in the end he knocked them aside for the very real reason that the job *was* doable.

But only if he took command. Only if all the jobsmen were picked by his own hand. And only if every nut and bolt was checked and double checked personally by him.

"I don't like this Alliance Naval Tracking Station orbiting on the edge there," Lynt was saying, displaying a sector map on his datapad. "It's an equal distance to the Stargate, and if it picks up an emergency signal from the base, it can override the gate's systems and whistle for a cruiser to blow us all to our respective hells."

"I know those bases," Jake stated. "They're entirely automated to cut down on costs. With a few signal interceptors placed about it, we can block all transmissions for a decent chunk of time."

Song and Lynt bit into their bladder burgers. Jake left his untouched. Both tried to hide their smirks, but Jake's saw.

"Something funny?"

"Does that mean you're in?" asked Song.

"Guess so."

Later that night, Cullidan poured out a concoction that smelled like it was dredged from the bleach pits of Hell. The liquid was ambrosia to the Eridani senses, deadly poison to any other race. The Human and Orion picked up booze suitable for their races and saluted the enterprise to come. Jake used an empty glass.

The mission was all on the jobsman's shoulders now. One night to rest, then off to collect the men and the tools.

Part II – The Prep

The Tich

Due to regulations, all interstellar corporations must deal in standard Alliance credit currency. Institutions given licenses to bank and trade in that credit were heavily regulated by the Alliance and chosen only after the most intimate scrutiny was completed, or a sizeable enough bribe was presented. These safeguards were in place to prevent an economic collapse of literal galactic proportions. As such, demand for sanctioned banks far outstripped supply.

When dealing with an asteroid mining operation, there is almost no chance that such a financial institution will be located anywhere nearby, but accounts still have to be maintained. Income, outtakes, payroll, regulations. The books must be balanced on a regular basis.

The routine tour of duty on an asteroid mine was six standard months, then the workers were shipped out for a two-month vacation – without pay, of course – to allow their bodies to readjust to a regular gravitational pull. Otherwise, their muscles and bones would begin to irreversibly atrophy.

When a worker shipped out, all of their information was transmitted to a nearby Alliance approved banking establishment. In the case of Maze Base One, time was booked on the local stargate com systems to transfer it to a bank on the planet Transit.

The plan in a nutshell was to invade the coms section of Maze Base One and repurpose the outgoing banking transmissions into several accounts of the jobsmen's choosing – albeit still on the planet Transit. They couldn't alter that part.

Unfortunately, this was not something that could be hacked from afar, the base systems had fail safes on top of fail safes. All such banking transmissions carried various subspace Alliance security identifiers to prevent forgery. The crew needed to get in there and physically change the transmission destinations.

That is where Jake had initially seen failure.

"That payroll transmission must be an automatic command locked into the coms unit," he had said. "Meaning you need override codes to alter where it goes, then reroute thousands of individual accounts. That'll take too long. And if you don't have the codes or if they change them at the last minute, we have to torture some guy for the new ones which means it takes longer. Then security comes down and a firefight happens."

Cullidan had smirked at that and sipped more booze.

"You're forgetting that all these AMC units are plug-and-play. They don't waste money on redundancies. The coms unit is not where the accounting is done. All of the digital ledgers are sent via hardline into the coms unit which sends them out blind to the Stargate."

"That makes it sound *more* difficult. Another set of pass codes. Another place we need to occupy."

"Except that it's standard policy for AMC to use Cwi-X78 converters to connect secure hardlines between units. Everything flows through it and I know for a fact no one has bothered to change the passcode on the converter since installation. We can intercept the material and alter destination codes right before it's all collated into one transmission burst. Course, we're gonna have to shop around to find the best device…"

Nom would know, Jake had thought.

Which was what brought him to a store near the residential sector of the city. The place was thick with little flying buzzing things that lit up and made weird noises. These weren't spy cams or anything sophisticated, just RC devices people bought for their children.

Jake had never played with toys, so he completely missed the point of them. Not that he was even remotely interested in the pastimes of others. The place was irrelevant. The owner was not. "Nom, where are you?"

No answer. The store itself was almost entirely automated. Everything was arranged around a self-checkout stand stationed next to the door. Jake could feel hidden security cams rolling over his skin. The floor practically bristled with electric panels which would stun any shoplifters.

"Nom!"

The back wall shuddered open, revealing a tinkerer's paradise. Tools, bits of electronics, crystal lattices, wires, fiber optics, ion burners, and shortwave converters were scattered everywhere. Six half-constructed devices of indeterminate purpose stood prominently on a similar number of workbenches. Cutters, welders, scanners, and polymer injectors hung from the ceiling above each one.

A wide purple face with a red beard as thick as a beehive slid into view. Nom grinned through rotten teeth. He was a Goola-Goola, a sentient from Gnoosie in the Heinock star cluster. The Goola-Goolas were technologically advanced, but had the organizing capacity of a pile of kittens. Their home planet was divided into thousands of loose city-states with no unified currency or government.

Goola-Goolas were welcome to travel, work, and even live in Alliance space. Special visas had been legislated to allow them in, but the race had no representation in the Alliance government. The Goola-Goolas didn't seem upset by this.

"Well, Mr. Pool," Nom said, wiping something sticky from his hands. "What bits of fun are we interested in today?"

The Goola-Goola listened carefully as Jake laid out the details of the mission, smiling with delight as the massiveness of the job manifested. Like Song, Nom was more interested in the achievement than the score. He began digging through old crates shoved in the rear of the workshop, pulling out various pieces of electronic gear.

"Most of the hardware will be standard for a break-n-crake. Thermal dampeners, code crackers, power shunts, and so on. For the Cwi-X78 converter, since you have the codes, you're going to want to utilize a device with speed. If it takes too long, an alarm might get raised. That's a minimum of thirty thousand alterations in five seconds. Not easy."

Nom was what they called a Tich, an Orion term adapted into modern jobman's slang. It meant a supplier of illegal technology useful for committing crime. As time marched on, the Goola-Goola race seemed to be cornering the market on this job.

Nom pulled a metal box from the table with a few wires and clamps dangling from it.

"Pretty straightforward. Hook your datapad in and enter the new material. It should just have enough oomph to alter the signals before someone notices the holdup."

Jake handled the box and ripped off the top, making sure it was not full of loose wires. He took in the circuitry, most of it barely above the molecular level. Very sophisticated. Very powerful.

"Very nice," he said and handed it back.

"One snag. It has to be attached directly to the converter in three places. Part of its power comes from leeching off the Cwi-X78's own backup battery. You can't tap into the line. Meaning someone needs to physically get into the grill works and attach it."

"No problem," Jake said. "I got a sentient in mind."

"That isn't the real problem though," Nom said, then went quiet, waiting for a response.

Jake didn't bite. He didn't believe in dramatic pauses and simply stared at the little purple man until Nom continued.

"It's to do with that Alliance tracking station near the asteroid belt. Just 'cause it's automated doesn't mean it's stupid. I reckon twenty-seven signal interceptors will be needed to blanket the station. The interceptors will also have to be disguised as regular asteroid debris. The problem is in the placement. The signal system will detect and instantly register any unusual activity. All the interceptors have to appear to drift into place through natural momentum. The only way to do that is to hand

guide them."

"Hand guide them?" Jake asked.

"You'll need someone in a heavily shielded ejection bubble to drift just out of signal range and roll them in place with an injection scoop calibrated with enough torque. That way all twenty-seven will orbit the station naturally. A hell of a job."

Indeed, it was. And it just might be the straw that broke this camel's back. It was not a job Jake would volunteer for. If anything went wrong, that man would be the first sacrificed.

"You got a body for that?" asked Nom.

"No."

"Good, then I volunteer."

That was a surprise. "You? Have you ever pulled a job before?"

"I won't be part of the regular heist. Just drop me off, let me work, and pick me up."

Jake was up against the wall here. Nom was a great Tich, no denying it, but that didn't mean he'd be any good on the job.

He'd seen it before. Amateurs hitching along who suddenly think they can act any which way because they're about to commit a crime. Most end up doing something stupid, getting caught, and spitting up everything to the hod.

In this case however, the needs of the job outweighed the potential problems. Frankly, there was no one else but Nom to stick into the slot. Jake reluctantly agreed.

"How much?"

"Just like everyone else. A pluth up the open division." That was a Goola-Goola idiom, roughly translating to "a piece of the action".

They shook on it. Jake's most sacred vow.

The Slip

There were five stone towns, underground cities, founded when Mylligan landed. Each had been divided up by what they offered the market. Here in Yoncuar - which translates to Hightown from the Orion tongue - one could buy all sorts of materials that did not require a physical presence. Access, intelligence, various other deniable services. It was also the perfect place to meet with someone about a future job.

The city had been built into an artificial cavern, hollowed out from a massive marble deposit. The cavern roof was sixty feet up to prevent all those nasty mental illnesses every species seemed to develop when enclosed in small places for too long. The illusion of natural light was obtained from massive photospherent balls

hanging overhead that let off all of the radiation of a yellow dwarf star. It almost felt like real sunlight.

With no natural atmosphere, each of the stone towns maintained its own biosystem. Nuclear powered bullet trains raced down tunnels between cities. The only signs of civilization marking the surface were docking bubbles and signal relays to aid in landings.

Jake watched a ship bearing Lynt and Song being lifted towards a docking bubble. It was destined for Transit, where the data currency transmissions would be beamed. Their mission was to establish dummy accounts at the banks on Transit for short term use.

The term "dummy account" here was a bit of a misnomer, because they had to be as real as possible. Song and Lynt had spent the last two weeks putting together their false identities. Despite ever tightening controls and refined security measures, it was impossible to stop identity fraud with a population in the hundreds of trillions spread across several galaxies.

The best way to do this was with DNA masking, where a virologic containment web was implanted under the skin which gave all modern ID devices a false DNA reading. It was painful to endure and took about a week to fully spread throughout the body's dermis. The web lasted four months before the body destroyed what it saw as a biological invasion. Song and Lynt would establish accounts under their false DNA patterns.

After they were gone, Jake descended into the bowels of Yoncuar's sewage and energy producing subsectors to meet with another invaluable asset to the team. At least, *this* team.

This job was bringing out all sorts of usual types. Most of the time Jake would not have had any use for this sentient or his kind, but as he had long suspected,

Under the right circumstances, anyone can be useful.

He bypassed a security door with skilled ease and plugged his nose against the stench of the city's underbelly. Before him was an old machine used to regulate the sewage system. Thousands of pipes connected to enclosed vats where the effluence of a hundred races mixed together. It was sturdy but slowly slipping past its prime. Even with daily checks on the seals, a foul smell managed to wriggle out.

Once a vat was full, it compressed, sucking up all of the oxygen, methane, and other useful gases, which were then shunted off to other facilities for recycling. The rest was then spat up onto the surface of the rock.

Once a month, cleaning crews would float out and chisel away the mountain of feces piled up around the ejection hatches, depositing the stuff on another part of the hollowed-out moon.

Around the machine's base was a mass of slick gray stone. At least, it appeared

so at first glance. But as Jake watched, he saw the mass shift and move and heard light rhythmic tapping.

"Swip Tum-Tum," Jake yelled.

The gray mass writhed. The tapping increased in volume and violence. Bubbles blew on the surface.

"Swip Tum-Tum. Get out here or I call security. None of you are supposed to be in this section and you know it."

That did it. All of the gray pulled together into a horizontal mound on the side of the sewage machine. From its top, a ball spat out. The thing rocked back and forth for a moment, then rolled up the stairs to Jake. The rest of the gray settled back down.

Jake took out a small harmonized device and stuck it into the ball. The gadget allowed the two races to communicate.

This was a Mazian, a creature which had no natural bone structure, sense organs – other than its dermis – or even organ sacks. It was as it appeared, a giant blob. Mazians did have a central ganglion mass which seemed to act as a brain, but it was nothing you could point to on the outside.

Mazians normally communicated by tapping on the ground, the race being particularly attuned to sonic vibrations. Dull loud thumping, like the one pulsating from the sewage machinery, being the most pleasant to them. The harmonizer translated the creature's tapping into Galactic Basic.

"Got a job which you might fit into," Jake said. "I mean that literally. We need you to squeeze into a tight area and handle some equipment."

"I think that's something I can manage," the synthetic voice replied.

One of the drawbacks of the harmonizer was that it gave no hint of mood. Some said the Mazian's had the ultimate poker face, but Jake knew it was only a matter of checking the creature's texture to see their emotional state. Right now, Swip Tum-Tum's surface was folding back on itself, over and over, indicating excitement.

Mazians were unique in being the only sentient race to never have developed a technology, not even Stone Age devices. When they were first discovered, the race hadn't even bothered to develop the wheel. Why should they? They could roll themselves anywhere.

"You'll be able to handle work on a Cwi-X78 converter? You'll be rewiring part of the hardline and inserting some delicate instruments."

"Sure. As long as I get a little practice, I can slip in anywhere and do and what needs done."

There was a reason why Jake had never used this species on a job before. A Mazian was a self-contained animal. It easily digested leftover organic matter in

whatever state of decay. It had no natural predator on its home planet and sported a tough dermis which could withstand temperatures between -25- and 190-degrees Fahrenheit without discomfort.

As it stood, there was no reason for the Mazian to do anything but tool about and absorb food scraps. That's what troubled Jake, the race had no real needs, no vices to exploit, no families to threaten.

So why was Swip Tum-Tum going along?

"Fun!" it said. "Besides, you're a good guy. I'd like to help you out. You don't even have to pay me."

Jake balked at that. It went against every one of his jobman's instincts. This would be a life-or-death situation. Why else would you do it if you weren't getting paid? The transaction of wealth, in one form or another, is what made one a professional. A sentient who came along just for the adventure was sure to cause problems.

"Don't worry," the Mazian kept saying. "We're pals, aren't we? I'll do it gratis."

Pals? Jake didn't have pals. He had colleagues. The people he knew were just that, people he knew. A means to an end. Ones who could help him pull off the next job, that's all.

Jake didn't have a personality that engendered friendship, or warmth, or love. What it did generate was trust. Trust in his skill, his planning, and him holding up his end of a deal.

No one ever wanted to have a beer with Jake, but when he ran a job, everyone got their percentage. In the long run that meant way more than how much people liked to socialize with him.

So, who knew where this Mazian was coming from? Maybe he was deranged. The psychology of the race wasn't really understood, if it could ever be by non-blobs.

Jake put his foot down. Swip Tum-Tum needed to understand the running of things right then.

"You'll take your percentage. You'll act professional. No goofing off. No exploring. You'll do your job to the letter and nothing more, or else I can't guarantee I won't be forced to kill you. Understand?"

"Absolutely," was the flat synthesized reply. The blob's skin had stopped folding.

The Doze

The flier, or doze in criminal argot, would've been called the getaway driver back in the olden days. It was a ship's pilot who could, after a job, blast the crew into

another solar system before anyone knew what was going on.

Decent piloting skills were an obvious must, but a good doze also knew how to avoid the staggering amount of detection sweeps which could be employed. He had to know what an enemy was likely to use and have a countermeasure in his bag. That meant constant updating and continuous research. For this heist, the doze slot was crucial. There would be no hiding on the asteroid base. They either got away or they were all dead.

Jake took a bullet train across the gutted moon to Bloncauer, or "the Boardwalk" as some called it. It was the gambling district where the greatest casinos in the galaxy glittered.

Bright and shiny objects sparkled in every direction. Dazzling people, dazzling meals, dazzling events filled every crevice. But Jake noted that not two blocks away from each of these embedded jewels of excess were several layers of flop houses, pawn shops, blood banks, and even a few organ harvesters, that circled the casinos like giant bathtub stains.

Jake did not like gathering everyone he needed on one sphere, lest some overzealous investigator start piecing things together, but the free port of Mylligan's Rock was almost made for jobsmen. He knew that Galactic Control most certainly had agents in place, noting down who came and left, but there was little the agency could do to prevent crime.

He had heard a rumor that the entire place was in fact a Galactic Control operation. That the tens of thousands of people working here were employed by that interstellar police force and every centimeter was bugged. They said, one day the signal would come down and, *SNAP,* the entire moon would be arrested.

Jake didn't pay any mind to this. Considering how much illegal activity he saw on a daily basis, he figured Galactic Control would have to shut down all other operations and spend decades in the courts prosecuting the events of just one solar cycle.

Jake entered The House of Numbers, once a massive system-sharing scam, it had turned legit and gone into the numbers racket on the other end. All forms of games of chance lay about. It was all pleasure here, as long as you kept gambling.

He walked to the far end rooms. Sports from the other side of the galaxy were beamed in for the patron's delight and misfortune.

"Goddamn son of a bitch. Get the ball!"

When the Human race's fertility rates fell into triple negatives, various Alliance powers had worked together to create a viable alternative to the species. Lest one of the most ardent supporters of the Alliance, and its ongoing war, go extinct.

The result was the Gen-Human. Faster, stronger, smarter, and better looking than the original, Gen-Humans were able to mate with their sire species and

eventually would strengthen humans as a whole.

These were not clones. Force-grown to maturity in vats, pre-programmed with a skill suite, and sent to work, each Gen-Human was a unique individual, culled from sperm and ovum. It had to be done this way, otherwise all sorts of genetic redundancies would begin popping up in future generations of humans.

"Get the fucking jammer up there! Parley it to the hangman. Parley! Parley! You fucking morons. Can't move, even in zero-g."

Gen-Humans were contracted to corporations for their first twenty years, then became free agents, able to forge their own destiny, able to work for whomever and even change their name. Which led to Jake's contact coming up with…

"Johnny Rocket."

"Jake Pool? Holy shit! Sit down. Have a drink."

Unfortunately, the tech boys had yet to find a way to genetically engineer good taste. Jake pushed away the drink offered by a hovering drone. He wanted to get Johnny's full attention, but the game on the center screen had the Gen-Human completely enthralled.

"Tell me Jake, what are you doing here?... What the? Garbage goal, man. It was out of the crease! Are they recruiting blind men to ref?" He waved away Jake's non-existent rebuttal. "I know it's all done by A.I., but damn. Maybe they got grease on their lenses."

The game Johnny was glued to was Cyball. Its goal, like ninety percent of sports, was for one team to get an object into an opponent's zone. Two teams were entombed in a giant cylinder in space and needed to negotiate a ball through a rotating playfield filled with hazards.

Jake never paid attention to Cyball or any other sport. The idea of gambling money on its outcome seemed wasteful. Still, he respected the game's popularity and never spoke against it. He even pretended to have a favorite team, the Alleged Sentients out of Louistin, in case anyone asked.

Jake waited.

"Go, go, go, go, go, GO! … Ah, *shit*!"

And waited.

"Jesus Christ. How many bounces is this thing gonna do? There ... Get it ... *Idiots!*"

Until finally,

"Game over, man. My life is a black hole of pain."

Johnny Rocket buried his head under his arms and wept drunken tears. The display at the table registered that the Gen-Human had just lost five thousand credits on the game. Guess you couldn't genetically engineer common sense either.

But whatever his faults, Johnny Rocket was a first-class doze, which is what kept

Jake at the casino. The jobsman cleared his throat.

"Oh yeah," the Gen-Human pulled himself up from self-pity. "Did you want to talk to me?"

Jake went into the job, while Johnny downed another drink. The Gen-Human's eyes narrowed during certain parts, but was nodding along by the end. He slammed the glass down.

"Count me in. Just a couple of odds and ends need to be handled."

"Like what?"

The Gen-Human's voice changed. It was all business now.

"I'd need to look over whatever schematics you have. I need to double check, but I can probably lock into the landing bay. Holding it however, *if* there's a problem, might be tricky. I'd be much happier if we bought a couple of defensive missiles – nothing out of the ordinary for AMC vessels – just to ward away any heroes. Let me show you the types I mean."

On his datapad, he pulled up various units for sale on Mylligan's Rock. The numbers were outrageous, but what price safety?

The pair shook on the deal.

"When do we go?"

"About two months."

The Thumps

Now that the technical positions were filled, all that was needed were some extra thumps. That is, pure muscle. Jake usually waited until the end to recruit these because idiots who could shoot and give a beating were a-couple-a-credit in a galaxy that had been at war for the last twenty years. The other spots were specialists, prima donnas. Now, he just needed to fill in the chorus.

Technically he, Song, and Cullidan, filled these positions, but Jake wanted a little extra something to tip the balance, and he had just the two thugs in mind.

Jake jumped a further bullet train to Glocaeur – or Lowtown – the leftover area which was used for housing support staff, security workers, technicians, and various other wage slaves who maintained Mylligan's Rock.

At the city, Jake hopped a transport tube over to the slummiest area of the slum city and stopped at a rock shack missing its front door. All the houses on the street were a one room affair, sharing a communal toilet at the end of the lane.

A massive viewscreen dominated the inside wall. It was tuned to a puerile game show called, "Urinated on From Above". The action was pretty self-explanatory, and it certainly amused the two gargantuan lizard-men lying on the floor eating fast food from a plastic bucket.

The Urd Brothers were Ram Pythons from the planet Pythos. Their actual names were Jai and Peh, but no one used them. They were so damn close in appearance most sentients couldn't tell one from the other, but as they were always hired together, no one ever had to learn.

Even Jake's precision brain had to admit they were practically identical. The only obvious differences being the color of their eyes. One was brown and the other slightly darker brown. But he didn't like to buck trends and simply yelled, "Hey Urds," along with everyone else.

"Knock knock," Jake said.

"Who's that? You ready for a beating, Freddy?"

One of the pair loomed in the doorframe holding a massive quarterstaff tipped with barbed metal on either end. When the lizard spied Jake, his green lips broke out in a grin, showing several layers of carnivorous teeth.

"Jake Pool," one Urd said. "Are you here to give us more money? You never stop by any other time."

"That's why we like to see you," chimed in the other.

Jake was offered some deep fried splukoliish from the bucket, but waved it away. He had no idea what splukoliish was, nor was he in a hurry to find out.

Mostly the Urds worked as part-time bouncers for the rowdier bars, but Jake had found them useful in a few jobs. They took orders and did not ask questions. Perfect thumps.

Rams hadn't progressed beyond the Iron Age when the Alliance had come roaring down from the skies onto the planet Pythos. Suddenly, their culture went from worshiping their sun to blasting between stars, from hammering metal by hand to donning synthetic polyscene armor rolled off an automated assembly line. This jump in technology, far beyond the ken of most of the race, is what gave the Ram Python their reputation for stupidity.

The Urd Brothers were a little smarter than others of their kind. Having been raised on an Alliance-run world, they were at least literate and could do basic sums – pretty much all that was required from the Alliance education camps. That had not stopped them from going bad in the end, but at least they could read the charge on the docket when being hauled before a judge unlike most others of their race.

Jake kept to the basics of what he needed from the Urds, not mentioning any potential problems or using words of more than two syllables.

They agreed, because of course they agreed. They never had to exert themselves much on any jobs run by Jake in the past, so why would they have to now? He gave the brothers an address.

"We'll start training for the job next week. Make sure you're there."

The Cip

For the final part, Jake needed to take a trip down to see Roddy the Cip, a human who had never seen Earth. Roddy had spent most of his life jumping from one illicit rock to another. A cip handled all sorts of incidentals for a job. IDs, costumes, even weaponry on occasion. Since the plan required the team to board an AMC base, they needed to look the part.

"That's no problem," smirked the Cip. "Best thing about AMC is they run everything on the cheap. One-size-fits-all uniforms. Economy IDs. Nothing special about the fabrics. But I think you're in extra special luck today."

On the outside, the Cip's shop looked like another stone bungalow, but hidden beneath it was a mechanized vertical warehouse, consisting of a series of boxes and platforms hooked around conveyor belts, synchronized to a keypad. A number was tapped in. A box rose from the depths. No records were kept. Everything in stock was lodged in the Cip's head.

What ascended was a plastic box with AMC markings across it. The Cip popped the crate's top, revealing about forty AMC special security uniforms, complete with boots, helmets, and gloves.

"These are the genuine article. Salvaged off of some ship debris over at the battle on Stilt. The Galactic Navy conscripted every ship to fend off the enemy's assault. None made it. For a while, it was a field day for scavengers."

"We're gonna need IDs to go with it."

"Easily done."

Jake gave the number and races of those involved, excluding Lynt and the Mazian. They quickly settled on a price and the uniforms were shipped.

Jake was satisfied. Everything was handled. No more planning. No more recruiting.

Now, they just had to do the job.

Part III – The Go

Jake peered through the viewscreen at the massive rocks floating by. The Maze of Orion was an asteroid belt discovered by the Orions – in case you were confused about that – hundreds of years in the past.

What made this belt stand out was its sheer size. Most asteroid belts were the remnants of failed planets, ones that had not congealed properly under gravity's gentle crushing. In this case, an estimated six to seven failed planets made up the Maze of Orion. Multiple theories existed as to why this had happened. None had been proven.

The target, Maze Base One, lay on the other side of the belt. Jake and crew were using the Maze's density to hide themselves from both the mining facility and the automated Alliance signal base.

Nom was in the docking port, making last minute checks before being tossed into space. Right now, the Goola-Goola was fiddling with his main ejection bubble.

Ejection bubbles were meant to be last minute survival gear in deep space. A back-up's back-up. They were what you used if your survival pod failed. It came with a modicum of pressurized air and nothing else.

They were cheap, but not very effective. An estimated ninety percent of people who used them died. Either from asphyxiation, dehydration, starvation, or debris popping the bubble. It wasn't that they were badly made, it was just that if you were ever in a position to need one, help probably wasn't close by.

Nom had modified his extensively, adding oxygen scrubbers to recycle the air, emergency powder rations, plenty of water, plus some propellant canisters to help shoot the bubble in the direction he wanted. The purple alien had little spherical signal interceptors strapped all over his body. Those, along with an injection scoop covering one hand and various other pieces of homemade survival gear made him look like a walking junkyard monster.

The Goola-Goola gave the thumbs up. "Let's show 'em," he said over the squawker with a wink and was flushed out into the frigid nothingness of the void.

We are here to go. The words flew up through Jake's unconsciousness. It was from an old Earth poet, which Jake's former – let's say handler – was fond of. Jake didn't really understand it, but every time he saw a sentient leap into the oblivion of space, the words returned.

It would take several hours for Nom to reach his position and start rolling the signal jammers into place. This was the waiting time, the calm before the storm, when anticipation nibbled at a man's nerves and everyone's bowels loosened just a

bit.

The toilets quickly became overused, especially after both of the Urds took a turn. Johnny Rocket, like a good doze, had thought of this and put backup flushers at the ready.

Jake did not partake in them, much to Song's seeming amusement. He spent all his time examining every aspect of the plan, as he had a thousand times previously. The jobsman didn't have an uneasy feeling or anything like that, but had learned from experience that thorough preparation was the best way toward success. And that meant constant review.

Try as he might, Jake could not come up with a flaw. That was not to say there weren't any. No plan survives contact with the enemy. But wherever the fault might lie, it was beyond Jake's ability to control.

They had spent the last two weeks going over and over each step. Cullidan, as the backer, had balked at some of the expenses, but only a little. He would be repaid tenfold after the pull was split.

Jake had even rented out holo-suites on Mylligan's Rock and ran mock drills through them, using the known configurations of AMC modular base units.

That was where Cullidan tipped his hand. The base had been in operation for so long, a full half decade past its estimated abandonment date, that various patches and make-shift workaround units had been created by the staff. Cullidan knew them all. The crew adjusted accordingly, but it only compounded Jake's suspicions that the whole job was personal for this wreck of an Eridani.

He's a weak link and yet we can't get rid of him. At least not until the job's done.

Everyone was in their AMC special security uniforms. They had rigged together a security transponder on the Asteroid Mining Corporations reserved frequency and installed it in Johnny Rocket's ship. All the travel passage codes were supplied by Cullidan.

The ship was disguised as a personnel crawler and repainted in AMC colors. The back half of the vessel was simply sheet metal covering the backup ion generators, which gave the ship double the power and thus quintuple the boost when activated. They would be kept hidden unless pursuit was at hand.

One hour. Two hours. Three.

The men shifted, snorted, scratched noses. Everyone looked apprehensive except the Mazian blob. He was quiet, apart from an occasional bulge rising to spit out a pocket of air from its innards. There was no small talk, no pep talk. Just flatulation and silence. Each sentient engaged in some sort of mental trick to pass the time. These were experienced jobsmen. They all knew about the interminable wait, wait, wait before the go.

"Pinpoint laser signal from Nom," Johnny Rocket yelled. Smart move. There

was no way to intercept that transmission except on a direct line. "He's in position. Starting the roll."

Which meant the waiting period began over again. They weren't going to hang around the entire time Nom was floating in the black, but he needed to get at least fifteen interceptors into position for them to begin to work.

Dead silence. Burp, sniff, cough.

One *more* hour. Two *further* hours. Three *agonizing* hours.

More shuffling. The jobsmen twitched in their seats, counted spots on the ceiling, adjusted and readjusted the straps on their armor, measured their weapon's charge for the fifth time. All while they clamped down on their urges to *do something god-damn-it, something other than just sit here!*

"Laser signal," laughed Johnny Rocket. "It's go time."

He kicked on the ship's ion drives and headed towards the mission. When the jolt of that initial thrust hit them, all the jobsmen breathed easier. *Finally*, they thought.

Maze Base One was constructed from three clamped together asteroids. Massive titanium pylons, embedded deep into the rock, kept it all in place, while flexi-steel tubes transported people and materials from rock to rock.

Everything in an AMC mining operation was standardized. A paint-by-numbers affair. Even the creation of an initial base's stone town was fit tab A into slot B. A suitably large asteroid was chosen, then hollowed out to specifications. The predetermined number of needed units were plugged in, screwed together, then sealed up. Instant city. Need an expansion? No problem. Plug in a few more units or move to the next asteroid and repeat the process.

The Maze of Orion was one of the best profit centers for the corporation, not so much because of the material, but due to its position.

As races branched out into the depths of space, they usually found that whatever mineral was rare on their planet could be found in abundance elsewhere. Thus, as the profiteer said,

"It all comes down to distance."

What a mining area yanked from the rocks was just as important as how close the base was to colonized planets. Planetary manufacturing tended to stick to whatever that terrain yielded. However, shipyards and other space bound construction plants found it easier to haul in ore via stargates and the standard shipping routes than dredge it up from a planet. The closer the mines, the less it cost.

Johnny Rocket's ship spun around the asteroid belt, affecting a travel signature parallel to a vessel having just come out of the stargate. They skirted into the base's short-range signal radius, an area where the corporation could blow you away and

legally claim self-defense.

"Broadcast coming in," reported Johnny. "Let's see if these codes were worth the price of admission."

"They're all good," Cullidan sneered.

The Urd brothers grumbled. Jake cooled them with a look. The Eridani certainly hadn't wasted his time worrying about being liked or respected. Jake didn't agonize much about the former either, but he devoted a lot of running time to being respected.

Cullidan didn't care what anyone thought about him – and not in a good way. When not training, the Eridani had either been drunk beyond senselessness, headed in that direction, or spitting venom at everyone around.

"Okay," Johnny Rocket said, "docking permission granted. Pod two as we wanted."

"Gear up," Jake commanded. "Helmets on. Visors tinted. Give them as little to see as possible."

"Bay doors open," reported Johnny. "Hold on for gravity transmission."

Everyone grabbed a strap. Johnny's ship had artificial gravity, as did most modern space vessels, but it needed to be switched off when the ship entered a secondary field, otherwise gravity would suddenly double, causing damage to man and machine alike.

They passed safely through the base's bluish-hued gravity screen, which automatically kicked in after the docking doors released, and settled down on a raised glowing dais. Everything pressurized. The jobsmen fell into ranks. The ship's hatch began opening.

"You're up, Song," said Jake.

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Drops of sweat formed a perimeter around Aleister Song's brow, threatening to run down his face. He had been picked for this part, not due to his acting ability, but because he was the only one who could reasonably squeeze into the stolen AMC special security officer's uniform.

Lynt might have fit better, but he was on Transit. If they were caught but the money was successfully diverted, he would still be able to retrieve the loot and sit on it for when the others could collect. At least, that was the theory.

The jobsmen all fell in behind him, except for Johnny Rocket who wasn't leaving the ship. Song presented his fraudulent credentials to the Docking Chief and Security Officer, who tapped their toes waiting on an explanation behind this intrusion. The Chief scanned the falsified ID code and projected it against Song's genetic helix.

One second. Two Seconds. *How long was this supposed to take?* Three seconds. Did that security guy just look at him funny? Four seconds. The Docking Chief frowned. *He knows! He knows it's all fake!* Five seconds. Song gripped his gun handle. *Jesus Christ! Gotta put a hole in this fucker's face*.

The Chief gave Song back his creds.

"Sorry about that. Energy pack is going on this scanner and it went into power-saver mode. Slows everything down."

"No problem," Song answered with false nonchalance.

"So, what's going on here?" asked the Security Officer. "There's been no deaths. No thefts. We're ahead of schedule on ore extraction. Why are the big boys paying us a visit?"

Song took a deep breath. He'd rehearsed this bit of babble and the possible replies for hours. He'd gone over it so much that the words had lost all meaning. He might as well be jabbering a host of nonsense cadences.

"More corporate espionage. Caught wind of a doppler strain on the last few transmissions. Looks like someone's trying to crack our codes and interfere with the running system."

"But that wouldn't be happening on our end," the Security Officer objected. "There has to be at least a dozen signaling stations between here and Transit, not to mention the stargate systems themselves."

Song shook his head sympathetically.

"Orders are to check every place down the line, including here. Local security is to stand down on this matter." The Security Officer was about to object, when Song put his hand up. "I understand. I wouldn't like it if I was on the other end, but this is the way it has to be. You could complain, but Corporate will just repeat what I've told you."

"All a waste of time," the Chief muttered.

"I know. I agree, but let's just get it over with and *then* tell them that."

The Security Officer well understood AMC's policy of "orders are orders" and, since his lunch was growing cold, waved the Special Security Detail through without much more thought. These things happened periodically in a large company. Best not to let it get to you.

Smugness claimed Song as they marched on up to the Communication Unit. *Job damn well done*. Jake could not have handled it any better, was incapable of doing it, Song mused.

He respected Jake, had followed him in on this job without hesitation, and trusted his tactical ability, but Jake Pool wasn't all he appeared to be on the outside.

It had taken a while for Song to catch on. While the sentient looked human, something else was going on. They had worked six jobs together and eventually he

picked up on all sorts of oddities about Jake's behavior, which had then led to a startling conclusion.

But right in the middle of a job wasn't the time to confront him about it. He'd have to wait till it was all wrapped up on the planet Transit.

The moment they were out of earshot of the landing bay, Jake reasserted command. Not that he needed to give any orders. They had all rehearsed it so much, muscle memory alone could have carried them through.

The Communications Unit was a 1300 square foot section, mostly taken up with machinery, and was designed for a maximum crew of five. Like every other section on the base, it was modular and could be hermetically sealed off and detached if needed.

The jobsmen hit it like a thunderbolt. Through his past jobs with Jake, Song knew just how to handle the situation. It was a three-point assault.

1. Strike fast and quickly. Always use the element of surprise.

Which was just what happened. Only four crew were on duty when the jobsmen stormed the section. The Urd brothers grabbed the startled people and herded them together in the center of the unit, not giving the crew any time to set off any alarms or scream their idiot heads off.

One woman tried to get up and run, but Jake planted a hard fist into her solar plexus and down she went, mouth flapping like a gasping fish. Each crew member had a weapon barrel stuck in their face. Jake issued a harsh command:

"Anyone tries anything, they die."

2. Lock things up quickly and keep it cool.

The Urd brothers took guard outside the section doors to make sure no one entered. Luckily, the jobsmen didn't need to coerce any of the crew for a code or to fake an 'all clear' signal. They just needed to be restrained so they wouldn't be underfoot.

"Now, we're going to tie you all up," Jake said, his voice eerily level. Song had seen him calm down some pretty hysterical people with this tone. "As long as you don't resist, try to get away, or call for help then you will be fine. If you do otherwise, the only thing you'll accomplish is your own death."

Each crew member had their mouths gagged, a bag placed over their head, and hands bound behind their backs with sealant foam – a spray gel that hardened within seconds to a density matching cement.

3. Keep discussion to a minimum and don't get distracted.

Everyone had a job and this was not the time to improvise. The Urd Brothers were to keep any stray crew out of the section, which they would do with as much force as required. Cullidan needed to prep the arrays to send the signal as normal. Swip Tum-Tum, who until now had been hidden in their equipment boxes, needed

to squeeze between the machinery and slip their little sabotage drive onto the Cwi-X78 converter. Song handled the security feeds, running maintenance checks and fouling them up for the next half hour. Jake supervised everyone and made sure the prisoners did nothing stupid.

So far, everything was fine. Everyone was doing their job. It was smooth. Damn smooth. *Too smooth*. At this point they had practically gotten away with it. A spending frenzy went on in Song's imagination. *I'm sure nothing will* –

Song yanked back the thought mid-sentence. Cockiness only provoked the Gods of Karma into messing with a body. Had he just jinxed himself?

***

It wasn't easy for Karen Hobbs, coms technician third grade for Maze Base One, to hold in her bladder, but she didn't dare ask the large man holding a rifle to her head for a potty pass.

Who were these lunatics? What kind of psychotic attacked one the biggest corporations on their own turf? The answer to that caused her to leak a little.

Terrorists. Rebels. ARM. Mercenary saboteurs from a rival corporation. Savage killers, willing to blow themselves and any innocents around to Hell's icy depths in order to send some pathetic political message that everyone would ignore.

She was almost relieved when they put a bag over her head. If she couldn't see them, she couldn't identify them. That meant they were less likely to kill her.

Didn't it?

Karen was laid out on the floor, presumably next to her co-workers. Soon, it seemed the invaders relaxed and started talking. She would've shut her ears if the power was gifted her, but the coms tech was forced to lie there and listen.

"Song, double check that the security overrides have taken. Sometimes the system twitches and needs to be reinserted," said a voice speaking Galactic Basic with an Eridani twang.

Was that ...?

"No names," a gruff voice barked. "Get the blob into position."

"Disabling the security links now," the Eridani voice said again. "Refilling it with maintenance spam…. There, security will be blissfully ignorant unless they're physically told."

It was! Cullidan!

From her perspective, it sounded like the invaders were tearing panels away from the walls. What the hell were they up to? But who could say with her former boss at the helm. His presence did not make her breathe easier. He was an incompetent, big talking, micro-manager whose solution to each problem was screaming at everyone.

She only hoped he hadn't noticed her, or that he wasn't fully aware of the details of his dismissal. Because it was Karen who got him fired.

The drinking on duty had been bad enough, but when he moved onto hard drugs … well, let's just say she had an intense case of schadenfreude turning him in. All it took was a "random" drug test and out he went. No goodbyes and no sorrow from any of his underlings.

What was he up to with this group of deranged killers? Or whatever they were. Nothing good, nothing healthy, she was sure.

***

Oh boy. Oh boy.

Squeeze. Push. Tuck. Roll.

Swip Tum-Tum was having a hell of a time. It imagined itself on the battlefront among other great Mazian warriors, storming the skies, striking down the enemy threat. True, this was only a criminal enterprise, but it was *action* nonetheless.

Up, over, push, squeeeeeeze.

Swip Tum-Tum rippled his skin along the electronic guts of the transmission apparatus and dragged itself forward. The area it needed to find was only ten yards from where the Mazian had been stuffed into the works. However, the space was packed with machinery with not a centimeter wasted.

Forward. Forward Down. Sliiiide. Puuuuull. Up. Up. Up.

It was a complicated maneuver. Normally, the Mazian could flatten out a lot thinner, but the rig it carried added too much girth and it was forced to take a roundabout route to the Cwi-X78 converter.

Tuck. Push. Push. Slither up. Slide down.

Swip Tum-Tum didn't mind the strain. It was doing a vital part of the mission. One that only he could accomplish.

Onto the beaches. Into the tunnels. One Mazian stood against them all. With skill and guile, the enemies' defenses fell before the magnificent blob. He let out a Mazian piping tune used on occasions of great joy. The race sang by pressing air through folds in its skin, so every symphony sounded like a collection of armpit farts, but Swip Tum-Tum found it inspiring.

Bend. Corner. Corner. Kitty-corner.

If only the place wasn't so damn dirty. The crew obviously had never gone into the inner guts of the apparatus to clean up after installation. The amount of filth and gunk was just incredible. It would take a week to scrub the particles from the Mazian's skin. And then….

Uh oh. Stuck.

***

From Jake's position, things were nominal. The prisoners were under control, everyone was doing their job, and security was blissfully ignorant. It looked good, but this was no time to relax. At this point, the job all hung on the Mazian blob – an amateur. And it was getting near transmission time.

"Two minutes," Cullidan reported.

The Eridani was puffing through smokes like it was the last hour of his life. Jake didn't mind that. The stress of the job, the increased rush of adrenaline, or alien equivalent, had strange effects on the body. If it kept the Eridani calm, let him smoke. Jake just made sure that Cullidan took all of his butts with him so he couldn't be later identified by DNA left on the filters.

"One minute forty-five seconds," Cullidan said with a hint of irritation in his voice.

"Skip the countdown," Jake ordered. "Just let us know when it's done."

As he had previously noted, everyone else had done their part. It was all down to the Mazian.

***

Great. Just great, thought Swip Tum-Tum. *First job and I'm too fat to squeeze through.*

Swip Tum-Tum's dreams of being the great Mazian jobsman were dripping down the drain.

Pull. Pull. Puuuuul. Make it through, no matter how much it hurt. Edges bit into the Mazian. It could feel its flesh tear, its liquids leak. Shockwaves of pain rolled through its dermis.

Pull. Pull. Pull.

It wasn't going to lay down. Not Swip Tum-Tum. Did Thump-Thump Ting quit during the Battle of Aciacon when it ran out of ammunition? *No!* Did Swoosh Tup-Tip roll over and die when left exposed in the arctic wastes of Hoolidoon? *No!* And did Pop Snap-Pup, the greatest living Mazian military commander, give up when its ship was floating dead in space after destroying five enemy vessels.

HELL NO!

Crack. The Mazian was...almost there… almost there ... *arrgh* … pain … *nearly* … pain … *nearly* … pain.

SNAP.

Relief. Relief. A casing the Mazian was stuck on bent back and broke off the metal struts holding the machinery in place. The equipment banged about, sending sparks flying, and made one hell of a racket. Still, Swip Tum-Tum was free. That was all that mattered.

As the Mazian rounded a corner, there lay its goal. The near mythical Cwi-X78 converter. The object of the quest. The blob surrounded it and pulled out the rig Nom had put together.

Now… what was it supposed to do next?

***

Culidan crushed out another smoke. It was his twenty-seventh since they'd taken over the unit. The Eridani wasn't nervous. He was angry, legitimately boiling over pissed off and he had no idea why. It had started with the clockwork precision in which the group had taken and held the area.

The job was running smoothly. *Too gods-damned smoothly.* Jake had done his work too well. There would be no muss, no fuss. They'd all be orbiting another star before the corporation's hounds even knew something was wrong. And once the fraud was found, the authorities still wouldn't know who had hit the base.

That was the problem, he realized. Culidan *wanted* all these stinking desk jockeys to know who had ripped them off, who had torn apart their pathetic security.

He should never have let Jake take control. Mercenaries were plentiful in the Alliance. That is who he should have hired, a bunch of killers. Because that's what he really wanted to do. Blow this place up and shoot all the smug fucks populating it.

Maze Base One was filled with scum, always talking behind his back and smirking about his family. His entire life they had been doing it, the faceless masses just out of range, a heartbeat from earshot. He heard them hidden around corners, behind window blinds, under manhole covers, even outside portholes in the vacuum of space.

Cullidan wasn't quite sure of their identities, but this damn gaggle of conspirators had ruined his life. First, they had denied him acceptance to the most basic military academies in Eridani territory, meaning that he would be ineligible even for his own family's honor guard. The lowest of the low in military terms, yet a position which would have allowed him a smidge of respect.

After that, his family conspired to throw him out, forcing him into degradation of having to join the private sector. He knew for some races success in business meant joining the ranks of society's cream, but for an Eridani it meant being cast as a second-class citizen.

There were further pits one could tumble towards in his culture, but Cullidan had side-stepped them by leaving Eridani controlled space and entering the Alliance workforce. He thrived for a time after joining the Asteroid Mining Corporation, taking management and technical courses and rising to the rank of Shift Supervisor of the Coms Unit at Maze Base One.

Of course, he hadn't really escaped his tormentors. The evil bastards were just setting him up for a great fall. He was fired publicly, stripped of his pension, and black-balled in the corporate world. They didn't even have the decency to kill him. They wanted to slowly drag out his painful existence until he committed suicide.

That was when Cullidan decided to stop playing their game and found Lynt. But now he realized what they had put together here was not good enough. These vermin needed to pay. Not just in money, but blood and flesh.

The Eridani played with a plasma grenade hooked on his belt.

***

Roll, roll, roll.

The stout purple man floated in the vacuum and aimed the device snapped onto his wrist. It was just like bowling the feiran when he was little – a pastime of many young Goola-Goolas, involving ricocheting a stainless-steel ball off of twelve sticks.

It required just as much knowledge of angles as it did skill. Nom had been pretty good back in his teens. Not professional good, but decent enough to beat the kids in his neighborhood. Back then though, the penalties for failure were only a few jeers from the other children. Here, a screw up meant, at best, twenty years in an Alliance penitentiary. At worst, death in the endless void.

Yet, he was not afraid. The weightlessness, the soundlessness, the odd bobbing of his body, calmed him. He placed a spherical signal interceptor into the injection scoop and made the calculations.

Eight more degrees along the y -axis, make sure it overlaps with the previous interceptor on the Py-rotations. There would always be some movement in the spheres, which is why it was important for their signal dampening arcs to intercept.

Yep, that was it. Go.

The sphere shot out of the scoop, rolling in an arc. His wrist datapad checked the thing's flight. With no inertia in space, he modified the interceptor's movements with little CO2 canisters. Otherwise, they would keep on traveling and eventually go out of range.

The pad lit up green. It was in position. He sent the stop signal and the canisters went off, slowing the ball down little by little until it ceased moving. Number twenty was in place.

In the distance, the tracking station remained dormant. Nom thrusted gently forward, looking to the base's sensors like just another rock gliding through the universe.

The ejection bubble tugged along behind him like a giant placenta. A host of tubes connected the pair. Air hoses, and the backup air hose, and backup's backup.

Nom was nothing if not methodical.

This is great!

He had spent too long preparing others to go off on their various illegal operations. Year after year, tough sentients, the backbone of the Alliance, who forged the path to civilization – or not – with blood, steel, and plasma had come to him for help. And while at least half of them never came back, Nom couldn't help but admire their courage.

Secretly, he'd always longed to go on one of those expeditions. To loot treasures of a forgotten world, or burn out a secret enemy nest, or be a part of a high-stakes heist. Things were winding down for him. Soon he would be past his prime, unable to keep up with technological trends, and thrown into the junkyards of tech-past like most elderly Goola-Goolas.

Before this opportunity, he had made do with old films of action and daring. He prized his complete collection of *Spiff Blasthandy* tri-vids. Now, he would have a real story and real memories of ripping off some corporate fat-ass.

Hmmm.

Was it his imagination or did the external lights around the station's docking ports suddenly illuminate?

***

Time was ticking. Swip Tum-Tum could tell it was close to zero hour. It ran through the procedure. Connect the device, siphon the battery with dual 56t clamps, recypher the crystal matrix, and then boot up an alternate processor rigger. It did all that and …

Nothing.

The Mazian was pretty sure there was supposed to be a noise when the battery siphon powered up the processor. A beep of some sort. But there wasn't.

Damn it.

It should have paid more attention during training, but Swip Tum-Tum had slacked off that last week, figuring it didn't need more.

They're gonna kill me.

It had no choice but to try again. Connect the device, siphon the battery….

Beep!

There was the needed noise. Oh, happy days! Swip Tum-Tum could breathe again. The device heated up. The alternate processor rig started to hum.

That was it. Everything was done. The only thing left was to slither back and collect the money.

***

"Transmission data received," Cullidan reported. "Collating now. Just a few seconds."

Everyone but Jake visibly tensed. This was the last moment. The last chance for some Cosmic Trickster to dip its sticky fingers in and gum up the works. Maybe a technical fault in the transmission apparatus would occur. Maybe Nom's gadgets weren't compatible with AMC's systems due to an unforeseen software update. Maybe someone in the group had sold out the rest.

"Collated. Loading transmission package," Cullidan's eyes scanned the screen, while the others hung onto the Eridani's words. "Loading still … Finished … Transmission away!"

Had they brought champagne, the cork would have popped right then. All the tension built up over the last two months leaked away.

They had done it!

The Mazian squeezed out of the ducts and rolled around, slapping everyone's hand with a meaty pseudopod. Even the Urd brothers came in and shared the joy.

It was a well-earned moment and Jake let it go on, but soon he snapped everyone back to focus. After all, this was just the tipping point. In a real sense, the job was only half done and any jobsmen worth the name knew not to relax just yet. No celebrating until the money is in your hand.

"All right," Jake ordered. "Start the cleanup and let's get out of here."

It was then he noticed Cullidan had snuck off.

***

With the small facilities available on the base, it was always mealtime for someone. A small kitchen, a small cafeteria, meant everyone had to be allotted their regulation meals within a limited window. Three squares for each crew member were served within a twenty-hour cycle. The room was continuously full. Cullidan hung in the doorway, watching the workers eat.

There they were. All the scum. All the villains who had stabbed him in the back, stolen his future, and shat on his name. A great desire seized him. He wanted to crack skulls, bite through knuckles, dismember knees, burn genitals, and taste the blood of every bastard chowing down as if nothing had happened, as if they had never conspired against him.

They needed to be ripped to pieces, their bodies beaten to blood pudding, then he would move on their families and continue to kill even unto the third and fourth generations of these vermin, the ones who had done him wrong. He itched to take one of his weapons and just open up on that crowd.

And as he thought it, the plasma grenade was in his hand. And before he could consciously connect what was going to happen, the sphere was flying into the

center of the room. And before he could thoroughly enjoy the mayhem, fifteen sentients were burnt to death when superheated plasma blew through them, while a further twenty-five went down with severe burns and missing limbs.

Not a bad start.

Cullidan unslung his laser carbine and started finishing off the survivors.

***

When the explosions and screams began, Jake knew he was going to have to blast his way off the station. He was ready for that, even if it wasn't the ideal exit plan. In fact, it was the worst-case scenario, apart from shipping out in a body bag. A lot of people were going to die. A lot of heat was destined to descend on their heads. Jake shot an emergency signal to Johnny Rocket through his datapad then hefted his pulse rifle.

Clean-up was supposed to take up to an hour, with the team splashing caustic substances on every inch of the section to wipe out any trace of DNA. But there wasn't time for that now, so Jake was forced to order,

"Burn it."

White phosphorus grenades were utilized, engulfing the entire coms unit in flame. Everything that could burn, did – including the unlucky technicians. They cried pitifully and writhed about as the substance ate through their bodies, reducing it to hot ash and greasy smoke.

Jake would have preferred it otherwise, but he had to be cautious. The Urd brothers didn't seem to care. Song was disturbed, but professional enough to bottle it away.

Swip Tum-Tum… well the blob's body wasn't shaking or twitching at all, which could mean one of a dozen emotional states. Not that Jake was too concerned about the Mazian's comfort. There was no time to pack the blob away, so it was tossed a laser and told to shoot straight.

"Can he even hit anything?" asked Song. The blob wasn't manifesting any eyes.

"He can hit whatever he wants as long as it's not one of us. *Let's go!*"

Jake took the lead. The others fell naturally in behind him, weapons at the ready. There was no bullshit now, no bluffing through. Any obstacle was to be taken down with maximum force.

The station was on full alert, which meant chaos reigned among the lower ranks. Alarms blared. Automatic "keep calm" announcements blandly told people to follow their emergency lockdown plans, but most of it was lost under howls and yelling.

Fistfights broke out. The overhead lights flickered for a few seconds. A screeching half-naked woman ran past. Workers scampered down the halls, arms

filled with stolen stationary. They saw the group's uniforms, and backed away. Only security was allowed firearms, so even if these crewmen wanted to fight, they couldn't.

A head popped out of a latrine.

"Is it true? Is it true?" the worker asked. "Is there a Flying Guillotine on board?"

"Yes sir," Jake responded. "Better get ba—"

The door slammed. A warbling cry of fear leaked through.

It was like that all the way through the station. Workers caterwauled. They cried. They hid in weird places with half of their bodies awkwardly hanging out. Some seemed obsessed with stealing. Others got drunk and threw bottles at people rushing by. The crew pretty much did everything but follow its emergency protocols. Either the base had fallen way behind on its disaster training, or else no one had paid attention while it was being conducted. Jake had no complaints. The chaos worked in his favor.

"Halt!"

Two security guards with standard issue AMC laser carbines blocked their paths. One yelled out in a commanding voice.

"You are to lay down your arms and –"

The sentence was never finished. The Urd brothers immediately opened up. While the security boy's laser carbines were good, they were squirt guns next to the lizards' pulse rifles. Souvenirs from the Urd brother's stint in the Galactic Marines, the pulse rifle fired accelerated plasma through a magnetic bottle powered by a miniature fusion reactor which unleashed an explosive force. Useless at long range. Deadly in small corridors and cramped space stations, as the two security men found out. Their bodies smeared the walls. A few solid bits and pieces remained behind, but most of their corpses had become scattered jelly.

Another member of security was spotted trying to break up a fight. Song put a well-placed hole in the man's head. They came across a further security man drunk under a desk. One of the Urds was about to kill him, but Jake stopped the lizard. The man was too insensible to be a threat.

One guard was encountered coming out of a toilet area. She was velcroing her pants up when she saw them. A dumbfounded look sprouted over her face. Jake put her down with one quick blast to the neck. Otherwise, there were no other immediate obstacles.

The real trouble waited for them in the docking bay.

***

One more dead. One more enemy fell to Cullidan's wrath. Every race under the

umbrella of the Galactic Alliance had fallen at his feet. A rainbow assortment of blood swirled across the floor. Gods, he was alive.

"ALIVE!"

This was the only true way for an Eridani to live. Cutting down enemies. Driving the weaker species underfoot. He channeled his ancestors, the heroes who had forged his house, and the Gods from Beyond who had bequeathed all of known space for the Eridani race to dominate.

"The steel of my sword cuts with a swiftness of a heart that is never dulled," he roared, quoting an old Eridani maxim.

On the floor, a human tried to pull his guts back in. Five shots exploded his head like an overripe fruit. He spotted an Orion cowering under the table, using a plastic tray to ward Cullidan away. He shot the creature in the groin, then, after suitable laughter, again in the heart. A poor Goola-Goola ran away, trying to defy fate. Two blasts to the ankles ended the retreat. Another in the skull finished his life.

"I do not bleed, because I refuse to!"

Heavy footfalls came down the corridor. Military commands were issued in Galactic Basic. Another plasma grenade tossed down the hall ended that noise. Cullidan peeked out. It was security boys this time, splattered across the deck. Bits of the dead men had embedded in the ceiling. Gore dripped down from above.

One wasn't quite dead, though much of his life was pouring from the stumps which used to be his legs. Cullidan loomed over his prey, feeling quite the predator, and cut the man's throat. The power, *ohhhhh the power*, just thrilled him.

He caught sight of another man darting through a T-junction. The Eridani pounced after him, pondering whether he should shoot the man outright or play with his guts for a bit. He turned the corner.

Twelve carbine barrels stared him in the face. Cullidan, the "mighty warrior", immediately dropped his weapon and stuck up his hands.

"I want to see a lawyer," he whined.

They answered by pulling their triggers.

***

The docking bay was a disaster area. The emergency lockdown alert had come down just as Johnny Rocket received the alarm code from Jake. In a lockdown situation, security wanted everything contained and unable to move so they could easily isolate and eliminate trouble. That meant all spacecraft would be hit with magnetic clamps to keep them immobile. The only way to avoid the clamps was to be aloft when they snapped.

And Johnny had done just that. Unfortunately, taking off without guidance

permission and hanging around in a sealed docking bay made it painfully obvious exactly who was the object of the security alert.

When the jobsmen entered the bay, all other shuttles had been crippled and most of the docking crew were dead. Security had tried to shoot the rogue ship down, but had gotten the worst of the battle and were barricaded in the control booth. Twisted metal and burnt corpses hung about like Christmas ornaments.

"We're here," Jake signaled Johnny Rocket via his datapad. "Scoop us up."

"No can do," the doze replied. "The bay doors are shut. You have to take the control booth and open them. The booth's blast shields are down and the lasers can't penetrate it, so I can't help you get in, but I'll try to keep any other security boys off your back."

Jake conferred with the others.

"Can we squeeze the Mazian in via the ducts?" asked Song.

"No. Once those blast shields are shut, the whole box is self-contained with an independent air supply," Jake replied. "That's in case the bay is opened into the vacuum of space. We can't bluff our way in either, since that's obviously our ship killing everyone."

"Then we just blast it open," yelled an Urd.

A typical Ram Python response and probably the quickest way to crack the mystery of the locked box. Jake agreed they had to do it.

But where to find enough explosives? An idea, a desperate one, hit Jake. He did some quick mathematics and confirmed it was possible.

"You're going to hate this," he warned Song, then signaled to the doze. "Detach and drop one of your missiles."

"What the hell are you doing?" yelled Song.

"We're gonna use the warhead to blast into the control booth."

"Are you crazy? It'll take out the whole booth and the hangar door will still be closed."

"Not if we tuck the warhead in the far corner of the bay. The door of the control booth will be destroyed, but most of it will remain intact."

"And our ship will be crippled as well."

"We'll have Johnny Rocket stick his ship in the opposite corner, as far as he can cram it. It'll take damage, but I've calculated it should survive. We can't have him fire one, because the thrust will push the blast too far into the structure to be of use to us."

"You've calculated that, huh? The yield and radius of the missile's warhead," sneered Song, but then caught himself. Of course, Jake Pool had. The sentient had the capability. "Let's do it," he said.

The Urd brothers jumped into action with no complaints, mostly because they

really didn't understand the argument. If Swip Tum-Tum had a problem, he kept it quiet. No one would have listened anyhow.

The crew started the process of removing the warhead from the delivery system without blowing themselves up. It wasn't *that* tricky. The missiles were built with secure safeguards to prevent accidental detonation. The Urds burned through the joints with acidizers and high-gauge blowtorches.

Metal fell away at a steady rate, but it was taking too long. Johnny had to repel a security team attempting to invade the bay. Jake wished Nom was with them. The tinkering Goola-Goola probably would've had the whole thing done in half the time.

Once they placed the bomb, the jobsmen would need to retreat back into the base proper to avoid the blast radius.

"How do we know this isn't going to blow a hole into outer space?" Song asked.

"Those bay doors are double thick, and the rest of the base is built into solid rock. It should be all right."

"Should be?"

"I'm doing the best I can," Jake snapped uncharacteristically. "I've heard nothing but complaints and no ideas come out of your mouth. This is the only plan we have. You can either shut up and trust me or go kill yourself."

Shocked, Song stopped talking and doubled his efforts. Jake never acted like that. It had to mean they were closer to death than ever before.

Finally, the warhead slid off. An Urd brother caught it before the explosive device hit the ground and quickly stashed the payload in the corner where Jake pointed. The jobsmen reached in and placed a detonator next to the missile's explosive element. He sent the activation code to Johnny Rocket then rounded up the crew.

Now, they had to punch their way back. Taking in the tensile strength of the metal structures, Jake estimated they needed to be at least three hundred yards away if they were to survive the blast.

As the group retreated, Jake considered reinforcing his "don't hesitate to shoot" policy, but there was no need. Everyone was on edge and popped off at any movement.

'What's that?" Song yelled.

All the jobsmen shot. Some air was singed. A few leaves were singed off a plant.

"Stay frosty," Jake said.

One hundred yards.

Move on. Move on.

The area was now empty. It looked as if the crew had decided to follow their emergency training after all. All the hatches were hermetically sealed. Except for the blaring alarm, there was no noise. No shadows flickered. No movement at all. Yet, Jake knew security was there, hiding somewhere, waiting to ambush.

Two hundred yards.

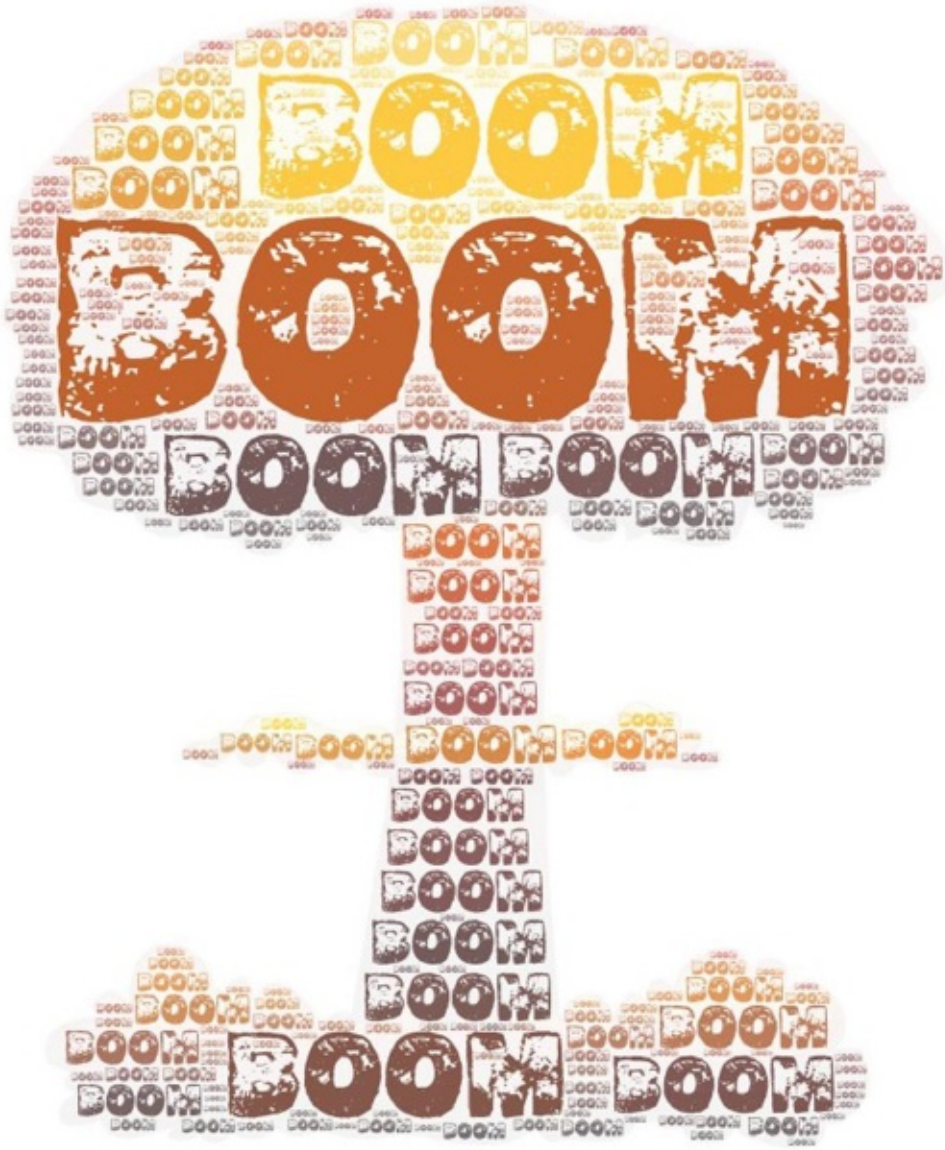
Move on. Move on.

Laser fire erupted from a junction. One of the Urd brothers was hit, but not down. The jobsmen returned fire, taking what cover was available. Back and forth the shots went, with none of them connecting. Neither side seemed able to hit the other. Suddenly, Jake caught some movement on the other end of the corridor.

They're trying to surround us. Mow us down in a crossfire.

He checked his datapad gauge. Three hundred yards in. Right on the line. It was a dicey call, but they couldn't afford to get boxed by a pincer movement. He signaled to Johnny Rocket,

"Let it off."


BOOM

Part IV - The Grab

Jake Pool shuddered back into consciousness and shook his head. At first, he thought his eyes weren't working properly, but soon realized there was simply an incredible amount of particulate matter hanging in the air. All sorts of ancient dust and hidden crud, bits of cracked sealant and errant powders, had been shaken loose by the blast, making everyone half-blind and coating their lungs with gunk.

The damage by the warhead was bad enough, but the sonic shockwave had caused internal problems Jake hadn't reckoned with. His feet were still a little wobbly, and his internal gyros hadn't recalibrated after the blast.

On the positive side, he was alive and basically ambulatory. That couldn't be said for most of the security men. Of those still breathing, not one seemed capable of lifting their heads, much less aim a carbine.

Jake checked on his crew. What was *left* of his crew. Swip Tum-Tum had been blown apart. Blackened streaks of the blob ran the course of the corridor. One of the Urd brothers had been nearly cut in half by a fallen beam. The lizard's body hung over a titanium girder like a puppet with cut strings. His lifeless eyes registered shock and confusion over its death. Jake used his final few phosphorus grenades to totally destroy the dead lizard's body.

Song however was still alive. Jake helped the human up, and felt loose bones grinding meat in the man's midsection.

Couple of broken ribs. Maybe a punctured lung.

A huge gash tore up the right side of Song's face, exposing the bone beneath. Song's eyes seemed unable to focus. Jake couldn't tell how much the man understood at the moment, but he managed to stumble in the direction he was pushed. That would have to be good enough.

The other Urd brother was fine. A few scrapes, some dented armor, and a busted weapon were the worst he suffered. Jake gave him his orders and off the lizard went, leading the way back to the docking bay.

A concrete jungle had emerged from the blast. Floors had fallen through, ceilings had dropped, walls inclined. Office furniture and smashed machinery blocked all the old hallways. Sparking power lines and various other cables hung about like jungle vines.

The Urd brother acted as their native guide, hacking a trail to safety. Smash. Toss. Roar. The brother, hysterical over his sibling's death, took his pain out on the obstacles. He bear-hugged beams out of the way, bit through steel, bent girders not meant to be bendable.

The amount of devastation was simply incredible. Everything was gone, blown through. Two stories worth of people and things had been hollowed out and filed in with the levels above. Most of the people in those sections were vaporized. A few stray bits of gore clung here and there, but mainly everything was black, charred, and twisted in an unnatural angle. The air, though of poor quality, was still breathable. Jake found it amazing there hadn't been a hull breach.

Eventually, they broke through to the docking bay. Jake had never seen such a heartwarming sight as Johnny Rocket's battered ship hovering in the corner like a tarnished angel. Jake was practically a stranger to emotions, but this got to him. Such relief. It was incredible. But there was no time to reflect.

"Open the bay doors," signaled the doze.

As had been stated, those control booths could sustain nearly anything. The front end was blasted inwards, but the systems were online and even most of the crew inside had survived, albeit abused and bruised into unconsciousness. The mechanisms were fairly simple. Everything was labeled in big red lettering.

With a colossal groan, the docking bay doors pulled open. There was damage, yes. The doors rolled back much slower than usual, yes. But damn, they built those things to last.

The gravity screen snapped up, keeping everything from being flooded into space. Their ship dropped down, engines idling. Its entrance floated a few inches from the floor.

The three remaining jobsmen stumbled aboard, well worse for wear. As the ship rose and whirled, passing through the gravity screen, Song passed out. Jake picked the man up and tossed him into the ship's auto-doc chair. The A.I. immediately began stitching up Song's face, sealing it back together with synthi-skin, while tubes injected themselves into his arms, topping off his blood.

The surviving Urd brother stretched out across a row of seats and immediately fell asleep. Just as well, Jake figured. His job was done. The jobsman just hoped the money would be worth the price of his brother's life.

"We're not out of the woods yet," Johnny Rocket yelled over the intercom.

Jake went into the cockpit and took the co-pilot position.

"What's the problem? The signaling station pick up a distress call?"

"No. Nom did his bit well. All transmissions to and from the station have been jammed, but their sensors definitely noticed those explosions. Their A.I. has launched probes to investigate."

"How long until they figure out what happened?" Jake asked.

"Not long enough. Once an explosion is discovered to be non-accidental, it's standard operating procedure to close the stargate until reinforcements or Galactic Control arrives."

"So, let's pick up Nom and get out of here."

"There's no time!" Johnny Rocket exclaimed. "We have to get out of the system now or else we'll be trapped."

"And Nom?"

"That's the question."

Seconds, long seconds, precious seconds, were spent on this deliberation. But in the end, there was no real choice.

Nom couldn't be brought back on board. If caught, he was looking at life imprisonment. If not, he'd die out there due to oxygen starvation. Captured alive, they could psychically rummage through his brain and get everyone's name. Dead, they could still track his DNA signature and compile a list of recent associates. His body had to be completely obliterated and there was only one way to do that.

"There," Johnny Rocket pointed. "That tiny speck on the scanner. That's Nom."

Again, there was no real choice. But no one wanted to say it out loud. If they did, the sin would be on their conscience, their soul. It fell to Jake, the leader, to utter the hard choice.

"Do it," he ordered.

A beam of energy shot from the ship. The speck disappeared. The spaceship raced towards the stargate.

***

Transit was a medium sized planet with an axial tilt and a quick orbital pattern. Daily rotation was eighteen standard hours. A year constituted one hundred and twenty-nine days in local estimation. Officially, the planet stuck to the Alliance calendar and simply put up with a few extra overlapping seasons each cycle. This was an Alliance colony world – rather than a member colony, independent dominion, or core world – and was thus freely open to any member race of the Galactic Alliance. Over seven billion sentients called the place home.

Transit was a key planet in its sector of the galaxy. Nearly every important corporation had a regional office present, either on ground or in one of the massive orbiting star-bases. Being adjacent to the Alliance maintained stargate meant that every signal boosting agency, the galactic stock exchange magnates, and communications outfit needed to be present as well.

And with such valuable hardware and a massive chunk of economic interest concentrated in one place, the Alliance couldn't let this baby go unguarded. One of the planet's satellites acted as headquarters for the 11th Alliance Fleet. Essentially, the planet was one big filing cabinet, cushioned with all the sleazy vices required by the modern corporate executive.

It was one standard day later and half a billion light years from the target of their heist. Typically, at this part of a successful job, everyone's spirits would be light and joyful. All they needed to do now was enter the bank and shift credits around.

Not today though. Too many had died, been sacrificed, to get to this point. Morally, it was a Pyrrhic Victory.

Financially, it was something else. A conservative estimation led them to believe that thirty million credits sat waiting for them. With only five jobsmen left that meant each share was an easy six million. One of their best scores ever. Yet, it failed to cheer any of them up.

Lynt joined them at the chosen mid-range landing platform outside the colony capital of Teijin. One glance at the ship and the Orion knew trouble had hit them. A further look at the crew and he knew it had been nearly catastrophic. Lynt had only mildly good tidings to bear.

One of Lynt's jobs on the planet, besides being a DNA false front for the money, was to keep a steady eye on all the data feeds and news flows, looking for information about their activities. Nothing had leaked out, or even been hinted at, about shenanigans occurring around the Maze of Orion.

"That doesn't mean they're not onto us," Jake said. "It just means they're keeping quiet. Eventually, it'll leak and by then I want to be in another galaxy. Hopefully they're still sifting through the carnage and trying to figure out what happened."

"So, we better finish this off now," said Song, wobbling in from the auto-doc's tender care.

Oh, the wonders of modern medicine. A few hours on the table, some body rehabilitation injections and synthi-skin spray, and the sentient had emerged good as new. Well, almost. Song was shaky. His body was still adjusting to all the foreign crap pumped into it.

There was no time to waste. Song changed into a business suit and he and Lynt toddled off to the bank. The final leg of the plan had the pair of them shooting the harvested credits across the Alliance in a financial zig-zag pattern. The money would go into successive smaller accounts, which would then be emptied into another account and closed, until they were all finally dumped into cloned numbered accounts held by a few disreputable banks on the fringes of Alliance space. All in all, it would take about three hours.

A collective groan from the remaining jobsmen shattered the heavens when the pair came back after twenty minutes. Another gods-damned problem. What could it possibly be? No one was in the mood for this.

"It's not a total loss," was Lynt's opening. "It's just that Johnny Rocket's auto-doc is a little too thorough."

"What are you talking about?"

"When the doc stitched Song back up, it accidentally erased the DNA masking web we had established his half of the dummy accounts under. They're unreachable. All of mine are fine. So, we got at least half the money."

Half the money? All that for fifteen million? It was not a sum to sneeze at, but it wasn't thirty. Jake was not going to give up. Not when there was one last card to play.

"Do we still have the false DNA sequence on file?"

Lynt handed over the data. "Here it is. But what can you do?"

Jake didn't answer. He shoved the Orion aside and entered the auto-doc's cubicle. After making sure the door was locked, the jobsman unhooked the medical scanner. This was a function he hadn't performed in a long time.

Jake programmed the phony DNA sequence in a holding pattern on the scanner, then jammed one of the device's prongs into the flesh of his forearm. He rooted it around in there for a few moments until contact was made.

The scanner display entered a split-screen mode. Jake's DNA sequence showed opposite the false one. A humming sound emanated inside Jake. His skin began to vibrate. Slowly, but surely, his DNA altered until both halves of the screen were identical.

Jake didn't look different, didn't feel different, but he would register under a different name. He wiped the medical scammer's memory and sealed up his arm. Everyone jumped when he reemerged. Jake grabbed Lynt.

"Let's go get the money."

"Are you sure …?"

Jake tossed the Orion out of the ship's hatch and the pair hailed a cab.

"How—" Lynt began, but Jake cut him off.

"If you ask any questions, I'll snap your neck."

Lynt believed him, remembering the body back on Mylligan's Rock. He looked out the window.

Like most colony cities, Teijin was heavily industrialized around its edges, but its center section had been reasonably civilized for more refined tastes.

Dainty public parks and impressive sculptures lay next to mammoth corporate offices and Alliance bureaucratic buildings. The taxi stopped in front of a forty-three-story building, imaginatively named the First Sanctioned Bank of Transit.

Foot traffic was swift. They had deliberately picked a peak time to do business in order to get lost in the crowd. Jake could feel the electronic transmissions in the air, adding, subtracting, dividing, buying, selling.

Before entering, each client stood at a circular booth and pressed a DNA marker – a digit, tentacle, or pseudopod – onto the analyzer. This verified that the

bank had accounts connected to the DNA signature.

Jake pressed his thumb down on the scanner. Lynt was in the cubicle next to him. He kept glancing slyly over at Jake, while feebly pretending not to. Lights blinked on the scanner.

One, two, three.

Lynt was through. He stopped on the other side of the glass, waiting for Jake to sink or swim.

One, two, three.

The scanner turned green and the chamber door opened. He had made it!

The pair split up. Each was escorted by a sentry orb into an isolation cubicle where they could conduct business.

Everything the jobsmen had to do now was routine. Shift, shift, shift. Money here. Money there. Over and over again. It would take the financial forensic department at Galactic Control months to figure out where it all went. And even then, there would be no clue as to the end receiver.

The hours melted away like minutes and it seemed as if no time had passed before Jake was finished. He pulled himself together and headed towards the exit, bumping into Lynt on the way out. All that exchanged between them was a quick nod. The money was theirs.

Halle-fucking-luyah!

That inward bit of glee was the only emotion Jake allowed himself. On the other hand, back at the ship there was no end to the joy. Song, the surviving Urd brother, Johnny Rocket, and Lynt screamed, yelled, imbibed, and let loose a general hoopla.

It had taken forever to plan, nearly killed them all in execution, but damn the payoff was sweet. Jake raised a toast with the others to their success, but did not join in.

***

After making sure everyone knew their final bank codes, the jobsmen split up as was their nature. Even the best crew eventually went their separate ways.

Johnny Rocket was taking Lynt back to his hovel on Mylligan's Rock and from there he was heading to an illicit drydock to repair his ship. The Urd brother bought a ticket back to his home planet of Pythos where he planned to hold funeral rites for his brother in the old-fashioned Ram Python tradition.

Song and Jake took rooms at an independent motel not far from the landing zones, a grimy joint that didn't require DNA signature for check-in, the place simply wanted all the money up front. Song went out and celebrated a bit more, while Jake made plans.

He wanted some more modifications on his systems. The process wasn't cheap and finding a technician who was reliable enough to stay quiet was even harder to find, but the jobsman had enough money to afford it now. Jake just needed to book passage to some of the dingier parts of the Alliance. Mylligan's Rock could probably handle what he needed, but he spent too much time there looking for work and this was ultra-hush-hush.

Late at night, someone pounded on his door. The hallway scanner revealed it was an inebriated Song making a dramatic entrance. Jake opened the door a crack.

"What is it?"

Song pushed his way in and parked himself on Jake's bed without taking off his shoes. He drank liberally from a bottle of booze glued to his right hand, then offered Jake a swig.

"No thanks."

"That's right. You don't drink," Song giggled. "Don't eat either."

"What's that mean?"

"We've been around a long time. Plenty of jobs. Plenty of planning. I've never seen you swallow a bite."

"I have strict dietary habits. Part of it requires privacy at meals."

Song guffawed, nearly spitting out the slug of the liquor he was swilling.

"Or is that your diet doesn't include human food at all, or anything most people would call food? Get over it."

Jake tensed. For years, the jobsman feared something like this might happen. He just hadn't expected it to come from Song's direction. Jake wasn't quite sure how to act.

"Get over what?"

"Come on Jake, or whatever your original number was. I know. I've figured it out. You don't eat. You don't sleep. You're super-fast at mathematics. And that last bit you did – rewriting your fake DNA signature – that sealed it. You're an I-bot, aren't you?"

I-bots were the creme de la creme of personal mechanized assistant devices. They were bodyguard, secretary, strategist, butler, and valet in one compact form. A must for the high-rolling executive. Corporations bought them in bulk and when an executive reached a certain level of sleaze, they were handed one along with their drinks cabinet and golden parachute.

To call them robots was a disservice. They were the ultimate fusion of organic matter and nanotechnology, maximizing the potential of the Genet Process which allowed one to create simulated living tissues from inorganic material. They were built tougher, their programming and computing abilities inlaid on a cellular level and strung together in a sort of gestalt nesting dolls fashion. They could absorb

knowledge at a phenomenal rate, calculate even faster, and even develop their own form of intuition.

Technically, they could be molded into the shape of any race, with the exception of the Mazian blob or the Andromedi energy beings. However, most races outlawed I-bots being produced in their likeness, resulting in the human mold being the most common.

Emotions weren't discouraged in the I-bot units. In fact, they were expected to grow fond of and loyal to their owners. It was one of their selling points.

"The computer on your side."

A trusted and competent companion who wouldn't leave and would willingly sacrifice themselves for an owner's benefit. After an executive was axed or retired, the unit was recycled, memory wiped, and reassigned to the next turd climbing the greasy pole.

It was only when they were left on their own, with no object of affection, that the I-bot became dangerous and could cultivate a sense of self beyond those who held their sales receipt. "Going rogue," they called it.

Not that Jake had much of a choice when he went rogue. He had been assigned to an executive at Space System Development Corporation, a conglomerate which specialized in deep space exploration.

Jake's executive had been doing a spot check at the corporation's main staging area for expeditions into the Greater Magellanic Cloud when the great enemy currently at war with the Alliance, struck. The ship attempted to escape into hyperspace, but its engines took a direct hit, spinning the vessel to the other end of the system.

By the time the automatic stabilizing systems got the ship back into line, the whole crew, including Jake's owner, were dead. It took months for Jake to steer the vessel back into civilized space. To do so, he had to learn to navigate the ship's controls, to maintain his body, and eventually to live only for himself. In that time, he found freedom and independence the tastiest of all dishes. And once rescued, he refused to give them up.

Jake took on his employer's identity long enough to empty the man's bank accounts, then changed names, then changed it again. Jake Pool was the eighth name the I-bot had assumed and the one which stuck. Over time, he'd established himself as a first rate jobsman, the only career which didn't require a background check.

Jake had hidden for years, kept others at a distance, but apparently it had not been enough. He had worked with the same people too many times and one had taken notice. Jake knew the black-market resale value of an I-bot and he wasn't giving up his sense of self without a lot of bodies piling up.

"I hope you passed that money along to your next of kin," Jake snarled, leveling a gun at Song's head.

"Whoa, hey," Song said, putting up his hands. "I'm just here to tell you, it's okay. I'm not going to rat you out. We've been through too much together. Things like that build a bond. I just want you to know you can trust me."

"Sure, I can trust you," Jake said. "Until you get at a low point and need some credits so you pass on a tip to some clitch for a finder's fee. Or get picked up by the hod and sell me out in exchange for dropping the charges."

"I could've done that before and I didn't. You know I wouldn't. We're friends, man."

Friends?

Jake didn't have friends. The men he knew were just that, the men he knew. Friendship wasn't part of the equation.

He pulled the trigger on Aleister Song.

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Rex Hurst is a writer from the prestigious Hurst family of Hurstberg, Germany. He first emigrated to the United States knowing only a slight smattering of English and taught himself up to a proficient level working as a taxi driver in the urban blight of New York City. He has eventually obtained Master's Degrees in Forensic Psychology and Linguistic Taxonomy. He is a writer and a university instructor after relocating to South Carolina. He also is attempting to discover if one can grow wheat in a pot sitting by the window. He is also co-host of the weekly radio show Write On SC.